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Dirty water supply triggers health fears



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PM SVANidhi transformed lives of countless street vendors: PM Modi



FILM: Pg 12

'Alia & Ranbir are my favourites'

Commercial LPG price hits new record high

Commercial LPG prices hiked by Rs 42 per 19-kg cylinder; no change in domestic cooking gas rates

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: State-owned oil marketing companies revised fuel and cooking gas prices on Monday, raising the cost of commercial LPG cylinders used by hotels and restaurants while leaving domestic cooking gas rates unchanged. In a separate move, aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices for international airlines were sharply reduced, offering relief to overseas carriers amid easing global fuel benchmarks, though rates for domestic airlines were kept unchanged for the second month in a row.

The price of a 19-kg commercial LPG cylinder was increased by Rs 42, taking the rate in Delhi to Rs 3,113.50 from Rs 3,071.50 earlier. The latest revision comes after a steep Rs 993 increase implemented on May 1, pushing commercial LPG prices to record levels. Prices of 5-kg free-trade LPG cylinders were also raised by Rs 11, with the new rate fixed at Rs 821.50 per cylinder.

TAKEAWAYS

- » Commercial LPG price hiked by Rs 42 per 19-kg cylinder; Delhi rate rises to Rs 3,113.50 from Rs 3,071.50
- » Domestic LPG price unchanged at Rs 913 per 14.2-kg cylinder; rates unchanged since March hike of Rs 60
- » 5-kg free-trade LPG cylinder price increased by Rs 11 to Rs 821.50



Hard work, not sycophancy, will help party; reconnect with grassroots

Rahul Gandhi

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CJP founder to return on June 6, plans protest seeking Pradhan's resignation

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke has announced that he will return to India from Boston on June 6 and launch a peaceful protest in Delhi demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over a series of examination-related controversies.

In a video shared on Instagram and X on Monday, Dipke appealed to students and supporters of the youth-led social media movement to join him in what he described as a constitutional and democratic campaign seeking accountability for alleged lapses in the education system.

"The time has come for all of us to come together, following the path of the Constitution, and peacefully raise our voices to demand Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation. If we raise our voices together, they will definitely have to listen to us," Dipke said.

The CJP founder, who recently completed a master's degree in public relations in Boston, said he would land in Delhi on the morning of June 6 and urged supporters to gather at the airport. He said the group would then proceed to the Parliament Street police station to seek permission for a protest at Jantar Mantar.

"I will arrive in Delhi on Saturday morning, June 6. Please join me at the

Dipke appealed to students and supporters of the youth-led social media movement to join him

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RE-TEST TO REMAIN IN PEN-AND-PAPER

SC junks plea to conduct NEET re-test in CBT mode

OUR CORRESPONDENT



Members of Krantikari Yuva Sangathan being detained during a protest against the NTA over the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak, outside Shastri Bhawan

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday refused to direct that the June 21 NEET-UG 2026 re-test be conducted in computer-based test (CBT) mode, saying the National Testing Agency (NTA) was already dealing with the fallout of the examination's cancellation amid a paper leak controversy, while senior NTA officials informed a parliamentary panel that their immediate focus was on conducting the re-test in pen-and-paper format even as the agency plans to transition the medical entrance examination to CBT from 2027.

The court's observations came while hearing a plea filed by RJD MP Sudhakar Singh and others seeking a direction to hold the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Undergraduate) re-examination in CBT mode instead of the existing pen-and-paper format.

A bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and Aravind Kumar declined to grant the request and posted the matter for hearing on July 27.

"There is no question of conducting the re-examination in CBT mode. They are already having too many problems. The examination was cancelled, and now it is being re-conducted. Either we dismiss this petition now or after the vacation," the bench

CLOSER LOOK

- » Court said the NTA is already under pressure after cancellation of the original exam amid a paper leak controversy
- » Petition sought conduct of the re-test in CBT mode instead of pen-and-paper format
- » Court observed: "There is no question of conducting the re-examination in CBT mode"

» OFFICIALS INDICATED THAT NEET IS PLANNED TO SHIFT TO CBT FROM 2027, FOLLOWING RECOMMENDATIONS OF A HIGH-LEVEL EXPERT COMMITTEE

told advocate Satyam Singh Rajput, appearing for the petitioners.

Rajput informed the court that the petitioners were pressing only one prayer, seeking the conduct of the June 21 re-test through a computer-based system. The bench, however, noted that similar pleas had been rejected earlier and urged the counsel to take into account the pressure currently faced by the testing agency.

Our territory won't be used against India's security interests: Myanmar

Both nations push for stronger trade, defence and energy ties

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Myanmar President U Min Aung Hlaing on Monday assured Prime Minister Narendra Modi that Myanmar would not allow its territory to be used against India's security interests, as the two leaders held extensive talks aimed at expanding cooperation in trade, defence, energy and other key sectors.

The assurance came during Aung Hlaing's five-day visit to India, his first since assuming the presidency less than two months ago following Myanmar's parliamentary elections



Prime Minister Narendra Modi exchanges a handshake with Myanmar President U Min Aung Hlaing, at Hyderabad House in New Delhi

held in December and January.

According to Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri, discussions between the two sides covered a broad range

of issues, including trade and economic cooperation, defence and security, border management, development assistance

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Iran halts talks with US after Israeli strikes in Lebanon

TEHRAN: Peace efforts between the United States and Iran have suffered a setback after renewed Israeli strikes in Lebanon prompted Tehran to halt the exchange of messages with Washington through mediators, according to Iranian media reports.

Iran's Tasnim news agency reported that Tehran and the Resistance Front, a coalition of allied groups in Yemen, Lebanon and Iraq, have prepared plans that could include a complete blockade of the Strait of Hormuz and the activation of additional pressure points such as the Bab El Mandeb Strait. The move is being framed as a response aimed at "punishing" Israel and its supporters.

The developments come as disruptions in the Strait of Hor-

The developments come as disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz have continued for more than three months following joint US-Israeli strikes on Iran on February 28

muz have continued for more than three months following joint US-Israeli strikes on Iran on February 28. The Bab El Mandeb, a strategic waterway near Yemen that connects shipping routes to the Suez Canal, has also been identified as a potential area of escalation if Yemen's Houthi movement opens a new front.

Continued on P4

THREE SHORT OF MAXIMUM PERMISSIBLE STRENGTH

Suvendu expands ministry, 35 MLAs take oath

MPOST BUREAU

KOLKATA: As many as thirteen Bengal Cabinet ministers, three ministers of state with independent charge and 19 ministers of state (MoS) were sworn in on Monday as part of the first expansion of Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari's Cabinet.

MLAs Swapna Dasgupta, Tapas Roy and Shankar Ghosh were among the 35 MLAs administered the oath of office as ministers by Governor RN Ravi at Lok Bhavan.

A carefully-crafted balance



Governor administers oath of office to BJP MLAs, on Monday

— based on geographical, ethnic and gender considerations — characterised the expanded council of ministers of the first BJP-helmed government in Bengal.

"The distribution of portfolios for the ministers will take place on Wednesday during a meeting which will be chaired by the CM at the secretariat," Cabinet minister Tapas Roy said. Union Home minister Amit Shah extended his wishes to the ministers who took their oath of office.

"I am fully confident that in the double-engine government, under the guidance of PM Shri @narendramodi ji and the leadership of Shri @SuvenduWB ji, you all will work with complete dedication,

Continued on P4

IMD WARNS OF BELOW-NORMAL SEASON RAINFALL

Monsoon likely to hit Kerala in 3 days, rain brings relief across north India

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The southwest monsoon is likely to reach Kerala within the next two to three days, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said on Monday, even as widespread rain and thunderstorms brought relief from heat across several northern states on the first day of June.

The monsoon normally arrives over Kerala around June 1, marking the beginning of the four-month rainy season across the country. The IMD said weather conditions remain favourable for its further advance into more parts of the southwest and southeast Arabian Sea, Lakshadweep Islands,



and parts of Kerala and Tamil Nadu during the coming days.

The department also forecast the monsoon's progress into

additional areas of the southwest, west-central, east-central and northeast Bay of Bengal, along with the remaining parts

CLOSER LOOK

- » North India gets heat relief: Rain, thunderstorms and cloud cover kept temperatures below normal across Delhi, Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh and Himachal Pradesh
- » Delhi's coolest June 1 in three years: Safdarjung recorded 36.3°C max and 24.9°C min, with daytime temperature 3.7°C below normal

of the southeast Bay of Bengal.

The latest outlook comes after an earlier forecast had projected the

Continued on P4

Don't take the Law into your hands, appeals Bengal CM

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Monday ordered a Special Investigation Team (SIT) probe into alleged irregularities in the "Lakshmir Bhandar" welfare scheme of the previous Trinamool Congress (TMC) government and appealed to the common people not to take the law into their own hands.

He maintained that the rule of law has been established in the state and assured that the police will take action against anyone involved in corruption or misappropriation as per the law of the land. Adhikari said investigators have stumbled upon 22 fake bank accounts through which

Continued on P4

Annamalai to address BJP exit and new party rumours in 2 days

MPOST BUREAU

CHENNAI: Amid growing speculation over his future in the BJP and reports that he could launch a new political outfit, BJP leader K Annamalai on Monday said he would make his position clear within the next two days.

Speaking to reporters at the airport before leaving for Delhi, the former Tamil Nadu BJP president declined to comment in detail on the rumours. "Please wait. We will sit down and talk in two days," he said when questioned about reports that he was heading to the national capital to meet party leadership and was considering quitting the BJP.

The speculation gained momentum after Annamalai publicly opposed the CBSE's recent decision to implement the three-language policy for Class 9 students from the current academic year. He had called for the notification to be withdrawn, leading to suggestions that he was taking a position at odds with the Centre and preparing to chart an independent political course.

The former IPS officer has largely stayed away from the spotlight since the BJP leadership replaced him with Nainar Nagenthran as the state unit chief and revived its electoral alliance with the AIADMK ahead of the 2026 Tamil Nadu Assembly election.

Continued on P4

SAKET COLLAPSE

MCD to identify & seal illegal structures across south Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two days after the collapse of a multi-storey building in Saket claimed lives of six people, the MCD is set to launch a crackdown on illegal structures in south Delhi, officials said on Monday.

According to senior Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) officials, the civic body is likely to begin a seal-and-vacate drive on Monday, identifying buildings that violate building bye-laws in south Delhi. “We will be issuing notices to all the unauthorised buildings having more than ground plus three floors (G+3). The drive will start in Mehrauli, Saket and other adjoining areas,” a senior MCD official said.

“Illegal construction is rampant in Saidulajab, Paryavaran Complex and Freedom Fighters’ Enclave in the Saket area alone. Similarly, in Mehrauli and nearby areas, illegal structures will be identified during an inspection,” an official added. According to officials, after the stipulated notice period is of 72 hours is over, the



corporation will take action, including sealing and vacating the building found in violation.

The MCD seals properties or issues vacation notices for unauthorised construction, severe structural deviations or the operation of unpermitted commercial activities in non-conforming zones, they said.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday posted on X that strict action will be taken against all unauthorised constructions. “Accountability will be fixed for negligence at

every level. No builder, official or authority is above the law. Violations will not be tolerated. The Delhi government stands with its people: committed to justice, accountability and public safety,” she wrote.

The multi-storey structure in Saket’s Saidulajab area came crashing down on Saturday, killing six people. The building housed a coaching institute, cafes and offices, while construction work was reportedly underway on its uppermost floor at the time of the collapse.

“It was actually my idea that she should open the canteen. Now I regret it,” she said.

‘She went back for the children’: Daughter of Saket collapse victim

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Neelam, daughter of Parvati, who died in the building collapse in south Delhi’s Saket, alleged that concerns about the structure’s condition had been raised earlier and blamed the building owner for the tragedy.

Six people were killed and eight injured when the multi-storey commercial building housing coaching centres, cafes and offices collapsed near Saket Metro Station on May 30. Neelam said her mother, who ran a canteen in the building for nearly four years, had managed to come out after signs of collapse became evident but returned inside to help students who were still trapped.

“It was actually my idea that she should open the canteen. Now I regret it,” she said.

Neelam claimed that pieces of concrete had fallen from parts of the building in the past and alleged that construction work had been continuing on the upper floors. She also criticised the initial rescue response, claiming the family repeatedly informed authorities about where Parvati was trapped.

Preeti, who helped run the canteen, recalled hearing loud sounds before the collapse and said Parvati turned back after almost reaching safety to warn students and others inside.

The family has sought compensation and demanded accountability. An FIR has been registered under relevant sections, including culpable homicide, and teams have been formed to investigate the cause of the collapse and identify those responsible.

Student injured in fire at Mukherjee Ngr building: DFS

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A fire broke out at a three-storey building in northwest Delhi’s Mukherjee Nagar area, leaving one woman injured, officials said on Monday.

The fire broke out at the ground-plus-three-storey building in Indira Vihar, which also housed a paying guest accommodation, late Sunday night, according to the Delhi Fire Service.

The call was received at 10.29 pm, following which five fire tenders were rushed to the spot. The fire started on the ground floor, where electrical items were stored, and spread quickly, engulfing portions of the building up to the second floor, the officials said.

All occupants of the building were evacuated in time and firefighters doused the blaze by 12.15 am. A woman student suffered minor injuries in the incident and was taken to a nearby hospital for treatment, they said.

Preliminary information suggests that the fire may have been caused by a short circuit, they added.

Police said in a statement that they rushed to the spot



“Prompt action was taken to safely evacuate all occupants, including the building owner who lives on the 1st floor”

soon after receiving information about the fire and found the building engulfed in smoke.

Prompt action was taken to safely evacuate all occupants, including the building owner, Surender Pal (65), who lives on the first floor, they said.

Furniture and other household items were damaged in the fire, they said.

Woman befriends mother, abducts infant from GTB

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A seven-month-old boy was allegedly kidnapped from the premises of the Guru Teg Bahadur (GTB) Hospital here on Sunday after his mother briefly left him in the care of a woman she had recently befriended, police said.

They said the infant’s mother, Nazreen (23), a resident of Seelampur, reported the incident to police, following which a kidnapping case was registered.

According to police, an unidentified woman befriended Nazreen in Seelampur about a week ago. The woman had been meeting her regularly and had gained her trust, police said.

On Sunday, the two women went to the GTB Hospital together and Nazreen left her son with her while she went inside to get a medical slip. When Nazreen returned, she found the woman and her son missing, they said.

A PCR call regarding the incident was received, following which police initiated inquiries and registered a case of kidnapping, an officer said.

Efforts are underway to trace the missing child and apprehend the accused woman, the officer said.

AAP seeks action after Saket tragedy

NEW DELHI: AAP workers on Monday protested outside the South Delhi Deputy Commissioner’s office in Green Park, demanding accountability over the Saket building collapse that killed six people.

Led by party councillors, protesters sought the resignation of South Zone Deputy Commissioner Rakesh Kumar, alleging repeated complaints about unauthorised construction at the site were ignored.

Delhi AAP president Saurabh Bharadwaj accused officials of failing to act despite being alerted to alleged violations.

Students grapple with trauma, uncertainty

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two days after the building collapse near Saket Metro Station, students and local business owners continue to grapple with its aftermath, describing trauma, uncertainty and concerns over building safety in the area’s bustling coaching hub.

Students attending classes at Arise Medical Academy, located adjacent to the collapsed structure, said books, notes, tablets and other study

‘It felt like an earthquake. The chairs started shaking and the lights went out’

materials were left behind during the hurried evacuation. Many are now worried about losing access to crucial resources ahead of examinations.

“It felt like an earthquake. The chairs started shaking

and the lights went out. For a moment, we thought we would not make it,” said a student, adding that around 150 aspirants were inside the building at the time.

The tragedy has also left a deep impact on the local community. Shopkeepers and fellow students remembered Kapil, one of the victims, as a hardworking and helpful young man.

According to acquaintances, he had recently travelled to Mumbai for a job interview and had gathered

with friends on Saturday evening after performing well in an interview for a position at the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre.

Residents and business owners said the incident has renewed concerns about ageing and poorly maintained buildings in the area. Nitesh Kumar, a coaching student, said repeated complaints about building conditions had gone unaddressed, while others called for a comprehensive structural audit to prevent similar tragedies.

Two held for Rs 2L cryptocurrency fraud

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two men have been arrested for allegedly cheating a 19-year-old Delhi resident of 2,000 USDT (tether) cryptocurrency worth around Rs 2 lakh after gaining unauthorised access to his crypto wallet through social media, police said on Monday.

The case was registered following a complaint by a man, a resident of Harsh Vihar, who alleged that he came in contact with an unknown person



on social media regarding the sale of USDT cryptocurrency.

According to the police, the accused later shared a number and, through fraudulent means, obtained access to the complainant’s crypto wallet.

“The cryptocurrency was

subsequently transferred to multiple wallet addresses. During the investigation, a police team analysed digital evidence and technical inputs to trace the suspects. Based on the leads generated, the team apprehended Sabir (23) and Rinku (28), both residents of Rajasthan,” a senior police officer said. Two mobile phones allegedly used in the commission of the offence were recovered from their possession. Further investigation into the matter is underway.

50-yr-old man killed after altercation; two minors apprehended

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have apprehended two juveniles for allegedly stabbing a 50-year-old man to death following an argument near a children’s play area in central Delhi.

The incident came to light around 11.30 pm on May 31 after a PCR call regarding a stabbing was received at Chandni Mahal Police Station. By the time police reached the scene, the injured man had been taken to Lok Nayak Jai Prakash Narayan Hospital by local residents, where doctors declared him brought dead.

Based on a complaint lodged by the victim’s 27-year-old daughter, police registered an FIR under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and launched an investigation.

According to the complainant, her father was standing

One juvenile stabbed him in the chest: Cops

near a children’s jumping pad at Suiwalan Chowk when he got into an argument with two local boys. During the altercation, one of the juveniles allegedly stabbed him in the chest while the other pushed the knife deeper before both fled.

Police formed a special team and examined CCTV footage, forensic evidence and local intelligence inputs. A blood-stained knife was recovered from the scene.

The accused, aged 16 and 17, were apprehended from the Turkman Gate area within hours of the incident. During questioning, investigators found that the dispute allegedly began after the victim objected to the juveniles’ behaviour while his six-year-old granddaughter was playing nearby.

Decomposing body of elderly woman found in bathroom

GURUGRAM: A 74-year-old woman’s decomposing body was found in the bathroom of her second floor house in the DLF Phase 2 area, police said on Monday.

The deceased, Rita Bakshi, reportedly lived in the house with her daughter, Rajni Bakshi, they said. On May 28, Rajni filed a missing person complaint at the DLF Phase 2 Police Station, claiming her mother had been missing since May 25.

Following the complaint, police visited the home twice but found no information about the woman.

On the evening of May 30, neighbours reported to police a foul smell emanating from the house.

A team was rushed and Rita Bakshi’s body in a state of decomposition was found in the bathroom.

The police suspect that the elderly woman slipped and fell in the bathroom, injured her head and died.

Man stabbed to death in Model Town; hunt on for accused: Police

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 25-year-old man was allegedly stabbed to death following a dispute with an 18-year-old youth in north Delhi’s Model Town area, police said.

The victim, identified as Sahil, a resident of Tomar Colony in Burari, was brought to Vinayak Hospital by his friends, Shiv and Shubham, on May 31. However, doctors declared him dead on arrival.

Police said a PCR call regarding the incident was subsequently received at Model Town Police Station, following which a team reached the hospital and launched an inquiry.

Investigators found that Sahil had sustained multiple stab wounds to his chest, back and neck.

Preliminary investigation revealed that the attack took

place in the MCD Colony area.

During questioning, eyewitness Shiv told police that the accused, identified as Ashu alias Lala, 18, a resident of Lal Bagh, allegedly stabbed Sahil during the altercation.

Police recovered the suspected murder weapon, a knife, from a location around 100 metres from the crime scene. Officials said the recovery is expected to play an important role in the investigation.

Based on the eyewitness account and other evidence, a case has been registered under relevant sections of law.

Police teams have been deployed to trace and arrest the accused, who remains absconding.

Investigators are examining the circumstances surrounding the incident and suspect the attack stemmed from a minor dispute over dominance. Further investigation is underway.

NOIDA-GR NOIDA CONNECTIVITY SET FOR MAJOR BOOST

Six-lane Hindon bridge nears completion

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Monday commenced a two-day refresher training programme for its senior civil and electrical engineers, with a focus on technical upscaling, contract management, and the use of artificial intelligence in public infrastructure projects.

The programme, being organised by the MCD’s Planning Department in collaboration with the National CPWD Academy, Ghaziabad, saw participation from more than 100 engineers, including Chief Engineers, Superintending Engineers, and Executive Engineers

from various MCD zones and departments.

Inaugurating the programme at the MCD Headquarters, Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar stressed the importance of continuous learning in an era increasingly shaped by technology and AI-driven solutions. He said engineers must regularly update their technical knowledge to effectively address emerging challenges in urban governance and infrastructure development.

“The insights and practical experience shared by experts during the programme will help officers improve decision-making and enhance the quality of public service delivery,” Khirwar said.

Senior officials present at the event included Additional Commissioner (Engineering) L.D. Meghwal, Engineer-in-Chief P.C. Meena, Planning Consultant Maneesh Rastogi, and Additional Director General (Training and Research), CPWD, Manoj Kumar. Several senior CPWD officers also participated in the sessions.

According to officials, the training covers key subjects such as General Conditions of Contract, contractual issues, quality assurance mechanisms, provisions of the CPWD Manual, public-private partnership projects, and the application of artificial intelligence in civil engineering.

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: A key infrastructure project aimed at improving connectivity between Noida and Greater Noida is nearing completion, with a six-lane bridge over the Hindon River now ready and the remaining approach road work expected to be completed by June 15, officials said.

The bridge links Sector 146 in Noida with the LG Chowk area of Greater Noida and is expected to significantly ease traffic movement between the two cities. Authorities estimate the new route will reduce travel time from nearly an hour to about 12 minutes, benefiting thousands of daily commuters.

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The bridge links Sector 146 in Noida with the LG Chowk area of Gr Noida and is expected to significantly ease traffic movement
- » Authorities estimate the new route will reduce travel time from nearly an hr to about 12 mins, benefitting thousands of commuters
- » Constructed by UP Setu Nigam, the bridge is around 200 metres long and designed as a six-lane structure. The approach roads on both sides are being developed jointly by the authorities

Constructed by Uttar Pradesh Setu Nigam, the bridge is around 200 metres long and designed as a six-lane structure. The approach roads on both sides are being developed jointly by the Noida and Greater Noida authorities.

Work on the bridge began in 2019 but was delayed due to various issues. Construction resumed around 18 months ago and has now been completed. Setu Nigam will also build a retaining wall as part of the project.

On the Noida side, an 810-metre approach road connecting the bridge to a 45-metre-wide road near Sector 145 is nearing completion, with around 80 per cent of the work already finished. The project is estimated to cost Rs 32 crore.

Meanwhile, on the Greater Noida side, around 70 per cent of work has been completed on a one-kilometre road linking Knowledge Park-III to the bridge. An overpass near Sector 146 is also being developed to connect the link road with the Noida-Greater Noida Expressway. Authorities aim to complete the remaining work on the Greater Noida side by December.

GULMOHAR PARK, ABUL FAZAL: DELHI GOVT LINKS CONTAMINATION TO AGEING SEWER INFRA

Dirty water supply triggers health fears

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: As residents of South Delhi's Gulmohar Park and parts of Abul Fazal recently grapple with contaminated water supply amid soaring temperatures, the Delhi government has attributed the problem to ageing infrastructure and long-pending sewer network issues, while highlighting a series of major sewage treatment and pipeline projects aimed at addressing the crisis.

The issue comes amid an intense summer spell, forcing many households to depend on bottled water and private tankers. Residents claim several people, including children and senior citizens, have reported stomach infections, diarrhoea, vomiting and fever in recent days.

In Gulmohar Park, one of South Delhi's prominent residential colonies, residents said the quality of water has deteriorated sharply over the past week. Sujata, a resident said, "The water looks and smells completely different from normal drinking water. We have stopped using it for cooking and are constantly worried about the health of children



and elderly family members." Another resident said families were spending additional money on water tankers and cleaning storage tanks. "Many of our neighbours have been falling sick including the kids.

Most of households are now relying on packaged drinking water because nobody is confident about the supply coming through the pipelines," the resident said.

In Abul Fazal, residents said contaminated water has become a long-standing problem rather than a recent development. A local resident remarked, "We are used to receiving this kind of water for years. The colour is often yellow, but we have no option

except to use the same water for washing, cleaning and other household chores." Residents shared that around 80-90 complaints have been submitted through the Chief Minister's grievance portal. The issue has been reported from several houses across A, B, C and D blocks of Gulmohar Park.

Following the complaints, Delhi Jal Board (DJB) Chairman and local MLA Satish Upadhyay recently convened an emergency meeting with residents.

Preliminary investigations reportedly identified possible contamination points near temporary toilets set up around construction sites and an old pipeline near Gate No. 2 that

CLOSER LOOK

» An official said 'in areas receiving alternate-day water supply, stagnant water in pipelines may initially appear dirty when motors are switched on, but cleaner water usually follows within a few minutes'

» Officials added that pipeline replacement work is already underway

was not properly sealed.

Government officials said the problem is linked to ageing infrastructure and inadequate maintenance over the past decade. An official said that "in areas receiving alternate-day water supply, stagnant water in pipelines may initially appear dirty when motors are switched on, but cleaner water usually follows within a few minutes." Officials added that pipeline replacement work is already underway.

The sources also highlighted a series of major infrastructure projects aimed at addressing sewage and contamination issues. As per the documents accessed by Millennium Post, during the

current financial year, DJB completed sewage treatment plant (STP) upgradation and augmentation projects worth Rs.2,014.98 crore.

The projects upgraded 305 million gallons per day (MGD) of treatment capacity and added 70 MGD through improvements at Keshopur, Kondli, Rohini, Coronation Pillar, Narela, Yamuna Vihar, Najafgarh, Nilothi and Pappankalan STPs.

In addition, 14 sewer-line, treated-effluent and house-sewer connection projects worth Rs.498.68 crore have been awarded across Karawal Nagar, Hasanpur, Tajpur Khurd, Ranholra, Gokulpur, Vikaspuri, Kamruddin Nagar, Sant Nagar, Wazirabad, Sonia Vihar, Molar Band and Sangam Vihar.

Officials said, everal STP projects initiated during the previous government remained delayed due to issues such as pending permissions and payment bottlenecks but have now been completed or are nearing completion. These include major facilities at Rithala, Okhla, Rohini, Narela, Kondli, Keshopur and Sonia Vihar.

The government further cited shortcomings in the execution of the Interceptor Sewer Project (ISP), launched in 2011 to curb Yamuna pollution. Officials claimed the project suffered delays of over seven years, failed to synchronise sewage interception with treatment capacity expansion and covered only 108 drains despite more than 200 drains discharging into the river.

Delhi's sewer network currently spans about 11,450 km, including 200 km of trunk sewers, 900 km of peripheral sewers and over 10,350 km of internal sewer lines. Officials said large sections remained undeshilted for years, contributing to sewer overflows and contamination.

To address this, DJB has awarded trunk sewer desilting works worth nearly Rs.200 crore across 30 packages and deployed 16 jetting-cum-suction machines for peripheral sewer cleaning at a cost of Rs.18.6 crore, with work targeted for completion before the monsoon.

Officials maintain that the ongoing upgrades, sewer rehabilitation and desilting efforts will help reduce contamination complaints and improve water quality across Delhi in the coming months.

Over 40 CPA staff transferred in Delhi health overhaul

Aims to improve healthcare supply chain

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a significant administrative shake-up aimed at improving transparency and efficiency in the health sector, the Delhi government has transferred more than 40 medical, paramedical and administrative personnel associated with the Central Procurement Agency (CPA), the body responsible for procuring medicines, medical equipment and other healthcare supplies for government hospitals.

Announcing the move on Monday, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the restructuring is part of a broader effort to make Delhi's healthcare system more accountable and responsive.

"Providing better medical facilities to the residents of Delhi is the commitment of our government, and any kind of negligence or indiscipline will not be tolerated," Gupta said.

According to the Chief Minister's Office, the transfers include 10 doctors, among them Head of Office Dr. Vinod Kumar Ranga. Additionally, 20 personnel from paramedical categories, including pharmacists, junior medical laboratory technicians, lab attendants and drivers, have been shifted to strengthen service delivery and operational efficiency.

The reorganisation also covers 10 administrative staff members, including officials at the levels of Section Officer, Senior Assistant and Junior Assistant. The government said a review of human resources within the CPA was conducted to assess staffing patterns and identify employees drawing salaries from the agency while working elsewhere, enabling better deployment of available manpower.

To further strengthen the procurement system, 12 medical officers from various government hospitals and health institutions have been attached to the CPA. These officers include Senior Medical Officers, Medical Officers and

TAKEAWAYS

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Chief Medical Officers who will assist in procurement, storage, supply-chain management and administrative functions.

The government has also redistributed responsibilities across key divisions, including the Project Branch, Store and Purchase Branch, Computer Cell, Mobile Health Scheme, RTI, PGMS, Child Rights, Health Mela and Hospital Coordination units.

Highlighting the objective behind the exercise, Gupta said, "The government is committed to ensuring that the procurement and supply system of medicines and medical materials is fully strengthened and better and time-bound health services are available to the residents of Delhi."

The government said the overhaul is intended to enhance institutional capacity and ensure greater transparency in the procurement of medicines and medical equipment across Delhi's public health system.

NDMC makes water free at all 38 Water ATMs

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a bid to provide relief to residents and visitors amid the ongoing heatwave, the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has announced that drinking water will be made available free of cost at all 38 Water ATMs across its jurisdiction from June 2.

The announcement was made by NDMC Vice-Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal during an inspection of Water ATMs in the NDMC area on Monday. He reviewed the functioning of the facilities, including water availability, hygiene standards, and service quality.

According to NDMC officials, 23 Water ATMs were earlier dispensing 300 ml of drinking water for ₹1, while 15 units already provided water free of charge. With the latest decision, all operational Water ATMs will offer chilled drinking water free of cost.

Chahal said the move was aimed at ensuring easy access to safe drinking water for pedestrians, workers, tourists, students, and other members of the public during the peak summer season. He added that the initiative aligns with NDMC's efforts to deliver citizen-centric civic services and promote public health.

A new Water ATM was also inaugurated at Nehru Park, taking the total number of operational units in the NDMC area to 38. The project, launched under the Smart City Mission, is intended to improve access to drinking water while reducing dependence on single-use plastic bottles through the use of reusable containers and eco-friendly paper cups. NDMC officials said all Water ATMs are currently functional and being maintained by the council's Water Supply Department.

FIR against advocates over PS ruckus

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have registered a case against several persons claiming to be advocates for allegedly threatening a police officer and obstructing him from performing his duties inside Shakarpur police station. The incident occurred on May 30 while an ASI was handling a road accident case. Police alleged the group pressured the investigating officer not to act against the accused driver, used abusive language and created a commotion inside the station. Separate FIRs have been registered based on complaints by the police officer and the victim's family. Further investigation is underway. **MP05T**

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major milestone for Delhi's public transport system, the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) has issued more than 10 lakh Pink Saheli National Common Mobility Cards (NCMC) within 90 days of their launch, making it one of the fastest large-scale digital mobility rollouts in the country.

Launched on March 2, 2026, the Pink Saheli Card enables women to travel free on DTC buses through a digital, paperless system. The card is based on the National Common Mobility Card framework and can also be used across

Delhi Metro, RRTS and other NCMC-enabled transport networks.

Transport Minister Dr. Pankaj Kumar Singh termed the achievement a significant step towards women's empowerment and seamless mobility.

"Crossing the 10 lakh mark within such a short period is a matter of immense satisfaction. The greatest joy is that this facility has reached our mothers and sisters. This is not merely a travel card; it is a step towards convenience, empowerment and integrated mobility," he said.

The minister said around 73 distribution centres across



Pink Saheli Card enables women to travel free on DTC buses through a digital and paperless system

Delhi are currently issuing the cards, with nearly 11,000 cards

Rooftop solar network grows to 23K installations

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi's rooftop solar network has expanded to more than 23,000 installations with a combined capacity of 420 MW, generating enough electricity to meet the daily needs of around two lakh households and institutions, discom officials said on Monday.

BSES discoms BRPL and BYPL have energised over 13,600 rooftop solar connections with a capacity of around 260 MWp, helping consumers save nearly Rs 200 crore annually.

More than 4,600 connections were added in 2025-26, including over 2,600 under the PM Surya Ghar scheme.

Meanwhile, Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL) has energised more than 10,000 rooftop solar installations with a capacity of 160 MWp.

Officials attributed the growth to subsidies under the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana and the Delhi Solar Policy, which have improved affordability for households.

Delhi Cabinet clears enhanced compensation for crop damage

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major relief measure for farmers affected by last year's excessive rainfall and waterlogging, the Delhi Cabinet on Monday approved a substantial increase in compensation for crop losses, raising the ex-gratia assistance to Rs.75,000 per hectare. The decision is expected to benefit nearly 10,000 farmers and pave the way for the disbursement of Rs.33.32 crore in relief.

The decision was taken at a Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta. Announcing the move, the Chief Minister said the enhanced assistance would be provided to farmers whose crops were damaged due to heavy rainfall and waterlogging during August-September 2025.

According to the government, around 10,977.44 acres (approximately 4,442.41 hectares) of agricultural land in Delhi suffered extensive damage after continuous rains and the overflowing of natural drains led to severe waterlogging in farming areas.

Highlighting the significance of the decision, Gupta said, "The government's decision will directly benefit around 10,000 farmers in the capital whose crops were severely affected due to continuous heavy rainfall last year and waterlogging in fields caused by the overflowing of natural drains."

“The decision will directly benefit around 10K farmers in the capital whose crops were severely affected due to heavy rainfall last yr”

“The decision will directly benefit around 10,000 farmers in the capital whose crops were severely affected due to continuous heavy rainfall last year and waterlogging in fields caused by the overflowing of natural drains.”

The Chief Minister noted that the previous compensation rate, fixed in 2015, was Rs.20,000 per acre, which worked out to nearly Rs.49,421 per hectare. She said that after more than a decade of rising agricultural costs, the government decided to revise the rate to Rs.75,000 per hectare.

A detailed assessment carried out by the Revenue Department found that crop losses in the affected areas were

as high as 100 per cent. Based on the findings, the Cabinet approved payment of compensation at the full revised rate.

Explaining the rationale behind the move, Gupta said, "The Delhi Government accords the highest priority to farmers' hard work, livelihood and agricultural security. When crops are affected due to natural disasters, excessive rainfall or other adverse circumstances, it is the responsibility of the government to stand firmly with farmers and provide them timely financial assistance."

She added that the decision aligns with the Centre's vision of strengthening agricultural security and increasing farmers' incomes. "This assistance will not only provide financial support to farmers but will also enable them to prepare for the next crop and ensure continuity of agricultural activities," the Chief Minister said.

The assistance will be provided to recorded landowners, while company-owned land, Gram Sabha land and farmhouse plots enclosed by permanent boundary walls have been excluded from the scheme.

I will personally monitor the progress of these works and ensure that industrialists get the facilities they deserve."

Addressing concerns over tubewells and borewells, he clarified that legitimate connections would not be affected and that action was being taken only against polluting units. He also directed officials to remove illegal encroachments from roads and public spaces, stating that such obstructions hamper industrial operations and infrastructure maintenance.

DDA expands Karamyogi housing scheme

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority's (DDA) Karamyogi Awaas Yojana has received a strong response, with more than 1,500 of the 2,101 flats initially offered under the scheme already sold. Encouraged by the demand, the DDA has launched an additional phase, making nearly 1,500 more flats available to eligible buyers.

According to Chinmayee Chakravarty, Deputy Director, DDA, flats in Pocket 6 and Pocket 9 witnessed particularly high demand, prompting the authority to introduce additional units in Pocket 13. She said the scheme has been implemented with complete transparency on a first-come, first-served basis.

Speaking about the possession process, Chakravarty said applicants may face delays in receiving possession letters due to mandatory verification by their parent government departments.

"The demand letter and possession letter are issued through the online portal after applicants create their IDs. However, possession can only be granted once verification from the concerned government department is completed," she said.

Chakravarty added that the DDA conducts regular inspections and quality checks to ensure construction standards are maintained. She said the flats are fully ready for occupation and highlighted ongoing infrastructure improvements in Narela, including enhanced metro connectivity and other development projects aimed at boosting the area's growth.

Officials said the scheme has been a major success, attracting significant interest from government employees and bureaucrats.

UDYOG NAGAR

Delhi govt promises lasting fix for waterlogging, infra woes

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a bid to address long-standing infrastructure challenges faced by industries in West Delhi's Udyog Nagar, Delhi Industries Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa on Monday assured industrialists of a permanent solution to waterlogging, drainage bottlenecks and poor road conditions, while announcing development works worth nearly Rs.45 crore in the area.

During a visit to the industrial hub, Sirsa interacted with

factory owners, workers and representatives of industrial associations, reviewing issues related to drainage, encroachments, roads and industrial operations.

Emphasising the government's approach towards industrial growth and environmental protection, Sirsa said, "Under the leadership of the Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, our vision is crystal clear: industries are absolutely essential to Delhi's development, yet protecting the environment is equally imperative."



He further assured stakeholders that he would personally oversee efforts to resolve the issues. "I assure you that I will personally and continuously monitor this entire matter to devise a lasting solution

“Internal roads, storm water drains and sewage connectivity will be completed on priority”

to all these issues. Industries must continue to operate, the environment must remain protected, and workers and entrepreneurs must be provided with a better, safer, and more organised environment," he

said. The minister announced that work on internal roads and storm-water drains within Udyog Nagar would begin shortly. Road development projects to be executed by DSII-DC are also expected to start soon, aimed at improving connectivity and infrastructure in the industrial area.

Highlighting the scale of the planned works, Sirsa said, "The Delhi Government is fully committed to upgrading industrial infrastructure. Internal roads, storm water drains and sewage connectivity will

be completed on priority. I will personally monitor the progress of these works and ensure that industrialists get the facilities they deserve."

Addressing concerns over tubewells and borewells, he clarified that legitimate connections would not be affected and that action was being taken only against polluting units. He also directed officials to remove illegal encroachments from roads and public spaces, stating that such obstructions hamper industrial operations and infrastructure maintenance.

India-US trade talks enter final stage as negotiators meet in New Delhi

Continued from Page 1

Towards negotiations on a more comprehensive trade arrangement.

The current round of talks follows months of negotiations after India and the US announced the framework for the first phase of the BTA in February. A joint statement issued on February 7 laid out the contours of an interim trade agreement while reaffirming both countries' commitment to a broader bilateral trade pact.

Under the framework agreed earlier, the United States had proposed reducing tariffs imposed on India to 18 per cent from

50 per cent. Washington had already removed a 25 per cent tariff linked to India's purchase of Russian oil and was expected to lower the remaining 25 per cent duty to 18 per cent under the agreement.

However, developments in the US legal and trade landscape complicated the process. On February 20, the US Supreme Court ruled against President Donald Trump's reciprocal tariff measures imposed under the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA). Following that decision, the US administration announced a uniform 10 per cent tariff on imports

from all countries for 150 days beginning February 24, a measure scheduled to remain in force until July 23.

The changes led to the postponement of a meeting between the chief negotiators that had originally been planned for February. Negotiations resumed in April when an Indian delegation led by Darpan Jain, Additional Secretary in the Department of Commerce and India's chief negotiator, travelled to Washington from April 20 to 23. The ongoing discussions in New Delhi are intended to build on those talks.

Officials from both coun-

tries are expected to work on finalising details of the interim agreement while continuing negotiations on areas covered under the wider BTA. These include market access, non-tariff barriers, customs procedures, trade facilitation, investment promotion and economic security cooperation.

One of the key issues for India is ensuring a tariff advantage over competing exporting nations. Sources indicated that New Delhi wants the trade pact to provide benefits beyond the current situation, where all US trading partners face the same 10 per cent tariff. India's com-

petitors in several sectors include Southeast Asian countries, Bangladesh, Pakistan and Sri Lanka.

Another area of discussion is the possibility of future US actions under Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974. The provision allows the Office of the United States Trade Representative to investigate what it considers unfair trade practices and impose retaliatory measures. Section 301 investigations can cover issues ranging from intellectual property rights and technology transfers to labour practices, subsidies and market access restrictions.

In March, the US Trade Rep-

resentative launched two Section 301 investigations involving several countries, including India, concerning excess manufacturing capacity and alleged failures to eliminate forced labour in global supply chains. India rejected the allegations and argued that the notices initiating the probes did not provide sufficient justification for the claims.

Officials familiar with the negotiations said India is seeking assurances that it would not face additional tariffs if an interim agreement is concluded. Reports suggest such protections could become particularly important once the temporary 10 per cent

tariff arrangement expires in late July.

The trade talks are also taking place against the backdrop of growing economic ties between the two countries. India has proposed reducing or eliminating tariffs on US industrial goods and a broad range of agricultural products, including dried distillers' grains, red sorghum, tree nuts, fruits, soybean oil, wine and spirits. New Delhi has also indicated its intention to purchase \$500 billion worth of US energy products, aircraft and aircraft parts, precious metals, technology products and coking coal over the next five years.

The United States was India's second-largest trading partner in 2025-26. India's exports to the US rose 0.92 per cent to \$87.3 billion during the fiscal year, while imports increased 15.95 per cent to \$52.9 billion. India's trade surplus with the US narrowed to \$34.4 billion from \$40.89 billion in the previous year.

With negotiations entering what both sides describe as the final phase, officials are working to complete the interim agreement while setting the stage for a wider trade partnership between the world's two largest democracies.

From Page 1

SC junks

The NTA cancelled the NEET-UG examination conducted on May 3 after allegations of a question paper leak surfaced. The Central Bureau of Investigation is probing the matter, and a fresh examination has been scheduled for June 21.

The issue was also discussed on Monday by the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports, which examined the merits and shortcomings of pen-and-paper examinations compared with computer-based testing.

According to sources, NTA Director General Abhishek Singh and other senior officials informed the panel that the agency's complete attention is currently focused on conducting the June 21 re-test smoothly in the existing format. They are learnt to have told the committee that NEET is expected to move to a CBT format from 2027, following recommendations made by a high-level expert committee aimed at improving examination security.

The parliamentary meeting was attended by Higher Education Secretary Vineet Joshi and Health and Family Welfare Secretary Punya Salila Srivastava. The committee, chaired by Congress MP Divyijaya Singh, had summoned the officials to discuss the advantages and disadvantages of both examination systems.

The debate over examination reforms has intensified following the latest NEET controversy and concerns surrounding the conduct of other national-level entrance examinations, including CUET-UG.

The Supreme Court has meanwhile been hearing a batch of petitions related to the functioning of the NTA, including demands for restructuring or replacing the agency with a more autonomous and robust body for conducting public examinations.

During a hearing on May 29, the apex court observed that young aspirants should not be disappointed and said the larger problem linked to medical entrance examinations would continue until there was "actual accountability."

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta had informed the court that the government was seriously concerned about the interests of students and that Prime Minister Narendra Modi was personally overseeing efforts to ensure that there were no shortcomings in the conduct of the re-test. He also said that new mechanisms had been put in place for the June 21 examination.

The NTA has also informed the Supreme Court through an affidavit that it intends to eventually shift NEET-UG from the pen-and-paper format to a computer-based system after consultations with the Centre.

The parliamentary panel is scheduled to meet again on Tuesday to review the use of the on-screen marking system in CBSE examinations and issues arising from technical glitches reported by students. The discussions come amid wider concerns over examination security, evaluation systems and accountability in national-level tests affecting lakhs of students across the country.

LPG price hits

Household consumers, however, were spared any increase. The price of the 14.2-kg domestic LPG cylinder remained unchanged at Rs 913. Domestic LPG rates have stayed at this level since early March, when prices were increased by Rs 60 per cylinder.

The changes are part of the monthly price review carried out by state-owned fuel retailers, with prices varying across states due to differences in local taxes such as value-added tax (VAT).

In the aviation sector, international airlines received substantial relief as ATF prices were cut by about 27 per cent. Industry sources said the reduction lowered jet fuel prices for foreign carriers by more than USD 400 per kilolitre, bringing rates to around USD 1,100 per kl.

The cut follows a period of sharp increases. ATF prices for international airlines had risen by USD 76.55, or 5.33 per cent, to USD 1,511.86 per kl on May 1 after more than doubling in April to USD 1,435.31 per kl amid a surge in global energy prices.

Domestic airlines, however, will continue to pay Rs 104,927.18 per kilolitre for jet fuel, the rate that came into effect on April 1. Despite higher international fuel costs in recent months, oil marketing companies had chosen not to raise domestic ATF prices in May in an effort to shield passengers from fare increases.

According to industry sources, ATF supplied to domestic carriers continues to be sold below cost. They said state-owned Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) are expected to incur under-recoveries on such sales.

The pricing decisions come against the backdrop of disruptions in global aviation fuel markets linked to the ongoing conflict in West Asia. Tightening jet fuel supplies and restrictions around the Strait of Hormuz, a key route for global energy shipments, have added pressure on fuel availability worldwide.

Sources said that while international carriers are being charged market-linked rates, domestic airlines are benefiting from a calibrated pricing approach adopted by the government and state-run oil firms to soften the impact of unprecedented increases in global energy prices.

There was no change in retail petrol and diesel prices. In Delhi, petrol continued to be priced at Rs 102.12 per litre and diesel at Rs 95.20 per litre after increases of around Rs 7.50 per litre last month. Oil ministry estimates show losses on domestic fuel sales, including petrol, diesel and LPG, stood at around Rs 650 crore per day in May.

Shubham Kumar

According to official data, 1,87,389 candidates registered for JEE (Advanced) 2026, while 1,79,694 appeared in both papers of the examination held on May 17.

The IIT Madras zone recorded the highest number of qualified candidates at 14,294. It was followed by the IIT Bombay zone with 12,389 successful candidates and the IIT Delhi zone with 10,697 qualifiers.

Candidates can access their scorecards and download the final answer key through the official JEE Advanced website by logging in with their roll number, date of birth and registered mobile number. The final answer key was also released on Monday.

JEE (Advanced) serves as the gateway for admission to undergraduate programmes at the IITs and several other leading engineering institutions across India.

Iran halts

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi said on X that the ceasefire between Iran and the United States applied "on all fronts, including in Lebanon." He warned that any breach in Lebanon would amount to a violation of the entire agreement and said, "The US and Israel are responsible for the consequences of any violation."

Tasnim reported that Iranian officials have insisted on an immediate halt to Israeli military operations in Gaza and Lebanon, as well as a full Israeli withdrawal from occupied areas in Lebanon. The agency said Tehran would not

resume talks until those conditions are met.

Tensions increased further after Israel announced renewed strikes on Beirut's southern suburb of Dahiyeh, a Hezbollah stronghold, citing repeated ceasefire violations. Iranian officials argue that the military action is undermining indirect negotiations with Washington.

Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei earlier said talks were progressing slowly due to deep mistrust, shifting US positions and ongoing Israeli operations, which he said were pro-longing negotiations.

AGENCIES

Myanmar

and regional developments. Both countries also expressed interest in strengthening collaboration in areas such as investment, health-care, education, energy and emerging technologies, including artificial intelligence.

"The prime minister reaffirmed India's support for the sovereignty and territorial integrity of Myanmar and both sides underscored the importance of preventing the misuse of sovereign territory for activities inimical to their security interests," Misri said after the talks.

He added that the Myanmar President specifically reiterated that Myanmar's territory would not be permitted to be used against India's security interests.

The issue carries particular significance as Myanmar shares a 1,640-kilometre border with India, adjoining several northeastern states, including Nagaland and Manipur, which have faced insurgency-related challenges over the years.

The leaders also discussed the ongoing peace process in Myanmar. Responding to questions on detained former leader Aung San Suu Kyi, Misri said Prime Minister Modi raised the matter during the meeting, largely in the context of efforts to achieve peace and reconciliation in the neighbouring country.

Explaining India's approach, Misri said New Delhi has consistently supported enduring peace, inclusivity and dialogue involving all stakeholders. "It was a bit of a free-wheeling discussion. I should underline that our engagement with Myanmar is not intended to be a commentary on the internal political arrangement in that country," he said.

Myanmar's recent elections were held after years of unrest following the military coup of February 1, 2021, which removed the democratically elected government led by Suu Kyi.

Ahead of the summit meeting, National Security Advisor Ajit Doval met Aung Hlaing on Sunday and discussed key aspects of bilateral relations.

The Myanmar President is accompanied by a high-level delegation that includes cabinet ministers, senior officials and business leaders. He had initially been scheduled to attend the International Big Cat Alliance Summit in New Delhi on June 1, but the event has been deferred.

As part of his visit, Aung Hlaing will travel to Mumbai on June 2 for meetings with business and industry representatives as well as site visits. Misri said the visit reaffirmed the commitment of both countries to deepen their long-standing partnership and pursue shared growth and prosperity in the region.

Suvendu

commitment, and spirit of public service and play a crucial role in realising the vision of a Sonar Bangla. All my best wishes are with you," Shah wrote on X.

Notably, three BJP MLAs from the Scheduled Tribe (ST) community and six from the Scheduled Caste (SC) category were inducted as ministers of state, taking the total

number of ministers from backward communities to 15—accounting for nearly 37 per cent of the state's Council of Ministers.

With Pramanik, a Rajbanshi leader and his Cabinet colleagues, Matua leader Ashok Kirtania and tribal community representative Kshudiram Tudu, already sworn in as Cabinet ministers, the total count of SC/ST leaders in the Cabinet stood at five.

With the induction of the new ministers, the strength of the ministry has risen to 41, three short of the maximum permissible strength.

Swapn Dasgupta, Sankar Ghosh, Arjun Singh, Tapas Roy, Sharadwat Mukherjee, Jagannath Chattopadhyay, Dudh Kumar Mondal, Deepak Burman, Manoj Oraon and Gouri Shankar Ghosh were sworn in as Cabinet ministers.

BJP MLAs Rajesh Mahata, Indranil Khan and Malati Rava Roy took oath as ministers of state with independent charge in the Adhikari-led government.

The ministers of state inducted into the Cabinet include Joyel Murmu, Harekrishna Bera, Ashok Dinda, Anandamoy Burman, Kaushik Chowdhury, Gargi Das Ghosh, Bhaskar Bhattacharya, Dibakar Gharami, Bishal Lama, Kalita Majhi, Amiya Kisku and Sumana Sarkar. BJP legislators Santanu Pramanik, Purnima Chakraborty, Umesh Rai, Nadiar Chand Ghosh, Moumita Biswas Mishra, Dipankar Jana and Biraj Biswas were also sworn in as ministers of state.

Interestingly, 10 MLAs from eight districts of North Bengal have found a place in the ministry. Among them, four have been made Cabinet ministers, one a minister of state with independent charge and five ministers of state. Biraj Biswas, MLA from Karandighi, is the youngest member of Adhikari's ministry, having been inducted as a minister of state at the age of 32.

Of the 54 Assembly seats in North Bengal, the BJP won 40 in this year's election. However, no MLA from Jalpaiguri, where the BJP won all seven seats, found a place in the ministry. South Dinajpur also did not get any representation.

Compared to the erstwhile TMC ministry during its third term in power, where eight of the 43 ministers were from north Bengal, the overall picture of the Adhikari council looked like a minor improvement in terms of representation from the region.

The swearing-in saw six women MLAs take oath as ministers of state, taking the total number of women ministers in the Cabinet to seven. Despite speculation, none of the BJP's celebrity legislators from the entertainment industry were inducted into the ministry.

On May 9, Adhikari was sworn in as Chief Minister at Brigade Parade Ground in the presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home minister Amit Shah, chief ministers of BJP-ruled states and senior party leaders.

Along with Adhikari, BJP MLAs Dilip Ghosh, Nisith Pramanik, Ashok Kirtania, Kshudiram Tudu and Agnimitra Paul had taken oath as ministers.

Sources said there could be a reshuffle in the portfolios allotted earlier now that a full-fledged ministry has been formed.

The expansion followed consultations between Adhikari, Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya and the party's central leadership in New Delhi last week over the composition of the council of ministers.

The BJP formed the government in Bengal after winning 208 seats in the 294-member Assembly in the recently concluded elections, ending the Trinamool Congress's 15-year rule.

Annamalai

Annamalai, who played a key role in bringing together TTV Dhinakaran and former Chief Minister O Panneerselvam during the 2021 Assembly election, was initially

expected by many BJP workers in the Coimbatore region to contest the 2026 polls. He later clarified that he would not be in the fray.

Questions over the party's state leadership have surfaced after the recent election, in which the BJP won only one seat. The NDA's hopes of making major gains in Tamil Nadu were dealt a setback by Vijay-led Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam.

A BJP source said Annamalai was unlikely to leave the party and could instead be assigned a larger role. However, some of his supporters in Coimbatore have backed the idea of him launching a new party as an alternative to the TVK.

Don't take the Law

benefits meant for women under Lakshmir Bhandar were allegedly withdrawn by men.

"We are investigating the wider network behind the alleged misappropriation of public funds. About 30 lakh Lakshmir Bhandar accounts are fake. The state government is determined to trace the roots of the alleged scam and ensure that those responsible are brought to justice," Adhikari said.

He claimed that , one account was found in the name of Rakibul, 15 accounts were allegedly operated by Mustafizur Rahman and his wife Tuhina, while six accounts were linked to Tarikul Rahman.

He added that several arrests had already been made in connection with the alleged fraud.

Referring to recent incidents of alleged attack on TMC leaders like Abhishek Banerjee and Kalyan Banerjee, Adhikari, in a veiled attack, said: " We know, such stray incidents are the outcome of public outrage and no political party is involved. If you have any complaints associated with misappropriation or corruption, lodge a complaint with the police for necessary action. Don't take the law into your own hands and desist from giving cheap publicity to a political party which is on the verge of becoming non-existent"

Defending the BJP government's detailed verification process for the newly launched Annapurna Bhandar scheme, under which eligible women will receive Rs 3,000 per month, Adhikari criticised the opposition for alleged spreading of misinformation regarding the application process for the scheme.

Adhikari announced that the online application process for Annapurna Yojana had become fully operational from Monday and expressed confidence that a large number of applications would be completed by Wednesday. The Chief Minister said that details relating to land ownership, bank accounts, family information and financial status were necessary to ensure that benefits reached genuine recipients. "The government will provide Rs 36,000 annually. Proper verification is essential to ensure that the rightful beneficiaries receive the money. When you go to the market and purchase lady's finger priced at Rs 20 per kg, you check the same on your own and then only buy it," he said.

The Chief Minister said that to facilitate the application process, administrative personnel have been deployed across districts to assist applicants. Both online and offline application systems remain operational, and officials may conduct door-to-door outreach in areas where applicants require assistance. 22 IAS officers in the ranks of Principal Secretaries/Secretaries have been assigned the responsibility to oversee the ongoing Annapurna Yojana across the districts of Bengal.

The state government has projected Annapurna Yojana as one of its flagship social welfare programmes and has emphasised transparency, accountability and strict beneficiary verification at every stage of implementation.

Monsoon

onset over Kerala on May 26. However, the arrival was delayed, prompting the IMD on May 29 to revise its assessment and indicate that the monsoon would reach the state during the following week.

While tracking the monsoon's advance, the weather department has also cautioned that rainfall during the 2026 southwest monsoon season is expected to remain below normal. According to its latest forecast, India is likely to receive rainfall equivalent to 90 per cent of the Long Period Average (LPA).

The LPA represents the average rainfall recorded over a region during a specified period, usually calculated using data spanning 30 to 50 years. For India as a whole, the seasonal rainfall LPA based on data from 1971 to 2020 stands at 87 centimetres. The IMD classifies a monsoon season as "deficient" when rainfall falls below 90 per cent of the LPA.

The department attributed the weaker rainfall outlook partly to the expected development of El Nino conditions in the Pacific Ocean. It said neutral El Nino-Southern Oscillation conditions are currently transitioning towards El Nino. According to the forecast, El Nino is likely to remain weak during June but could strengthen to moderate or strong levels by September. Such conditions are generally associated with reduced monsoon rainfall over India.

Meanwhile, rain-bearing weather systems brought cooler conditions across large parts of north India.

In Delhi, the Safdarjung observatory, which serves as the city's primary weather station, recorded a maximum temperature of 36.3 degrees Celsius and a minimum of 24.9 degrees Celsius on Monday. The maximum temperature was 3.7 degrees below the seasonal normal, making it the coolest start to June in three years. The last lower maximum temperature on June 1 was recorded in 2023, when the mercury settled at 32.7 degrees Celsius.

Other stations in the national capital also reported temperatures well below normal. Palam recorded a maximum of 35.5 degrees Celsius, Lodi Road 35.2 degrees, Ridge 35.6 degrees and Ayanagar 35.4 degrees. No rainfall was reported in Delhi during the previous 24 hours. The IMD said temperatures are expected to rise gradually from Tuesday as the current spell of rain activity weakens.

A similar trend was observed in Punjab and Haryana, where temperatures remained below normal following rain over the weekend. Chandigarh recorded a maximum temperature of 36 degrees Celsius, more than three degrees below normal.

In Haryana, Ambala reported 36.1 degrees Celsius, Karnal 32.8 degrees, Hisar 38.4 degrees and Rohtak 38.3 degrees Celsius. In neighbouring Punjab, Amritsar was the hottest location at 36.3 degrees Celsius, while Ludhiana and Patiala both recorded 35.6 degrees Celsius. Most locations remained around 4 to 5 degrees below seasonal averages.

Rajasthan also witnessed a change in weather conditions as rain, strong winds and isolated hailstorms affected more than 10 districts, including Nagaur, Phalodi, Chittorgarh and Ajmer. The IMD linked the activity to active western disturbances influencing the region.

Rainfall during the past 24 hours included 20 mm in Chittorgarh, 13 mm in Nagaur, 12.6 mm in Ajmer and 11 mm in Niwai of Tonk district. Although Phalodi remained the hottest place in the state at 43.8 degrees Celsius, maximum temperatures in most cities stayed below 40 degrees Celsius. Jaipur recorded a high of 38 degrees Celsius before cloud cover and evening showers lowered temperatures. A yellow alert for thunderstorms and rain remains in place for several districts until June 5.

In Uttar Pradesh, Fatehgarh was the hottest location with a maximum temperature of 42 degrees Celsius, followed by Basti at 41 degrees Celsius. Lucknow recorded a maximum of 34.1 degrees Celsius, which was 6.1 degrees below normal.

Rainfall was reported from several parts of the state, including Sultampur with 14.8 mm, Fatehpur 7.3 mm, Fursatganj 6.6 mm, Azamgarh 3.8 mm, Hardoi 1.6 mm, Jamesian 1.2 mm and Gorakhpur 0.1 mm.

In Himachal Pradesh, light to moderate rainfall continued across many areas. Sarahan recorded 34 mm of rain, followed by Kalpa at 26.4 mm, Sangla at 17.4 mm, Shimla at 13 mm and Kufri at 12.2 mm. Other locations including Dhaulakuan, Poanta Sahib, Tabo, Solan and Manali also received rainfall.

Dense fog reduced visibility in Shimla, officials said. Kukumseri in Lahaul-Spiti recorded the state's lowest minimum temperature at 4.3 degrees Celsius, while Una was the hottest during the day at 37.2 degrees Celsius. The weather office has issued a yellow alert for thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds at isolated places in the state between Wednesday and Friday.

As the monsoon prepares to enter mainland India through Kerala, the recent spell of rain across northern states has brought temporary relief from summer temperatures, while forecasters continue to monitor the progress of the season and the evolving El Nino conditions over the Pacific.

CJP founder

airport, and together we will go to the Parliament Street police station to seek permission to hold a peaceful protest at Jantar Mantar," he said.

Speaking to reporters later, Dipke acknowledged concerns that he could face arrest upon his return to India but maintained that his planned protest falls within the constitutional rights to free expression and peaceful assembly.

He said his greater concern was the threats allegedly directed at his family. "I'm not much worried about the threats I received personally. But the threats that I received for my family, I am a bit concerned about them. Because my family did not choose to do this; it was my decision. They shouldn't be dragged into this," Dipke said.

He added that he was returning to India solely to hold a peaceful demonstration and seek the minister's resignation. "Now it's up to the authorities to follow the same," he said, referring to constitutional principles. The CJP, launched last month, has gained visibility on social media and attracted support from several public figures. In his video, Dipke claimed that examination controversies and disruptions had left students anxious and called for accountability from the government.

According to him, an online petition demanding Pradhan's resignation has collected around eight lakh signatures. He also claimed that protests over education-related issues are already taking place in Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan and Maharashtra.

Dipke alleged that more than one crore students had been affected by examination-related controversies involving NEET, CBSE, CUET and SSC GD, creating uncertainty about their academic future.

"If the education minister does not resign even after such a massive blunder, it means there is no such thing as accountability left in our country," he said. While acknowledging fears among family members and friends that he could be detained on arrival, Dipke said he remained hopeful that authorities would permit a peaceful protest.

Calling himself a follower of Mahatma Gandhi, BR Ambedkar, Bhagat Singh and Jawaharlal Nehru, he said his faith rests in the Constitution. "And as for the fear of jail, how long will we live in fear?" he asked.

The announcement comes amid growing scrutiny of the Education Ministry following the cancellation of CBSE's re-evaluation process. The Congress and several opposition parties have demanded Pradhan's resignation, citing alleged administrative failures in the conduct of examinations.

COMPLETION OF SIX YEARS OF THE SCHEME

PM SVANidhi transformed lives of countless street vendors: PM Modi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday said the PM SVANidhi scheme supporting street vendors has transformed the lives of countless hawkers by ensuring access to collateral-free credit, financial inclusion and new opportunities for growth.

On the completion of six years of the scheme, he also said that PM SVANidhi is all about trust, dignity and empowerment. "Today we mark #6Year-sofPMSVANidhi, a scheme which has transformed the lives of countless street vendors by ensuring access to collateral-free credit, financial inclusion and new opportunities for growth. This scheme is all about trust, dignity and empowerment. My best wishes to all beneficiaries whose determination and enterprise continue to strengthen our nation's economy," Modi said in a post on X.



PM Narendra Modi

The Prime Minister Street Vendor's AtmaNirbhar Nidhi (PM SVANidhi) is a central sector scheme supporting street vendors through affordable working capital, financial inclusion and social protection measures.

The PM SVANidhi was launched during the COVID-19 pandemic to provide afford-

able working capital loans to street vendors whose businesses had been severely affected. As the first dedicated micro-credit scheme for street vendors, who constituted a significant part of the informal workforce and often had limited access to formal credit, it aimed to support the growth of their businesses while promoting financial

Highlights

- » Modi said that PM SVANidhi is all about trust, dignity and empowerment
- » The Prime Minister Street Vendor's AtmaNirbhar Nidhi (PM SVANidhi) is a central sector scheme supporting street vendors through affordable working capital, financial inclusion and social

protection measures

- » The scheme was launched in June 2020. It is a joint responsibility of the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) and the Department of Financial Services (DFS)
- » The scheme has benefited over 75.5 lakh street vendors across urban India

inclusion.

The scheme was launched in June 2020. It is a joint responsibility of the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) and the Department of Financial Services (DFS).

More than 1.12 crore collateral-free loans worth over Rs 17,800 crore have been disbursed under the PM SVANidhi

scheme since its launch in June 2020, emerging as a key driver of financial inclusion and economic empowerment for street vendors.

The scheme has benefited over 75.5 lakh street vendors across urban India, helping them access formal credit, adopt digital payments and avail social security benefits.

UNION MINISTER KHATTAR ON GYMKHANA CLUB NOTICE

‘Govt can take back leased land wherever required’

India to host 13th BRICS Urbanisation Forum in New Delhi on June 11-12

NEW DELHI: India will host the 13th BRICS Urbanisation Forum in New Delhi on June 11 and 12, 2026, bringing together ministers, policymakers, urban planners and experts from BRICS member nations to discuss strategies for build-

ing inclusive, resilient and sustainable cities.

At a press gathering before the forum began, Union minister Manohar Lal introduced the meeting as one of the key ministerial events during India's leadership of BRICS in 2026. **MP08T**

department. He added that since there was no state government in Delhi at that time, the Union government became the owner of the land.

"In most cases, land has been given on lease. The leased land can be vacated depending upon

ing on the BRICS Urbanisation Forum to be hosted by the HUA Ministry on June 11-12.

He said that wherever there is a requirement, the government can take back its land.

On May 22, the L&DO, under the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry, asked the Delhi Gymkhana Club, where the city's powerful and elite have rubbed shoulders for nearly a century, to return its expansive 27.3 acres by June 5 on the grounds of "securing defence infrastructure".

The sprawling premises, situated at 2, Safdarjung Road, in the heart of leafy Lutyens' Delhi, were leased to the Imperial Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd (now known as Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd) for maintaining a social and sporting club. **MP08T**

Cong accuses Dharmendra Pradhan of jeopardising future of 45L students

Calls for immediate resignation of Union Education minister

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Monday questioned the circumstances under which the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) awarded its On-Screen Marking (OSM) tender to Coempt Eduateck, alleging that eligibility conditions were repeatedly diluted to favour the company over Tata Consultancy Services (TCS).

AICC spokesperson Pawan Kherra, called for the immediate resignation of Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan, accusing him of jeopardising the futures of nearly 45 lakh students.

Kherra laid out a series of alleged changes to the tender process, saying that the DPI quality norm for scanned answer sheets was lowered from 300 to 200, requirements



Congress Leader Pawan Kherra addresses a press conference, in New Delhi, Monday **PTI**

for robotic high-speed scanners were dropped, and conditions around past performance, financial standing, and prior blacklisting were removed. "Only the penalty provision was retained which the company would obviously pay from the enormous sums it charges students," he said, pointing out that around five lakh students had paid Rs 2,000 each for revaluation, amounting to approxi-

mately Rs 100 crore.

The Congress spokesperson also alleged that the requirement for the vendor to maintain its own data centre was dropped and that cybersecurity norms were weakened ahead of the contract award.

He questioned Coempt's track record, citing what he described as a "shady" performance history in Telangana, and asked the Prime Minister to explain the company's alleged links to the BJP ecosystem.

Kherra also raised broader concerns about the Education Ministry's performance, listing NEET, CBSE, and UGC-related controversies as evidence of systemic failure. He said the OSM system had been imposed on 18.5 lakh students within weeks of rollout despite warnings from teachers and experts about 36 major flaws.

BJP top leadership discusses organisational appointments

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The BJP's Central Election Committee (CEC), which met on Sunday to finalise candidates for the upcoming Legislative Council (MLC) polls in Maharashtra, is learnt to have reviewed organisational preparedness and discussed pending party appointments at both the national and state levels.

Party sources said, the meeting was chaired by BJP president Nitin Nabin and attended by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and it also understood to have discussed the long-pending formation of the BJP's Uttar Pradesh organisational team under newly-appointed state unit chief Pankaj Chaudhary.

With Assembly elections in Chhattisgarh: Voting concludes for urban and Panchayat bodies

OUR CORRESPONDENT

RAIPUR: Voting and bypolls to vacant and newly constituted urban local bodies, as well as three-tier panchayats, concluded in Chhattisgarh on Monday, with voter turnouts of 84.58 per cent and nearly 78.61 per cent recorded in civic bodies and Panchayat polls, respectively, officials said.

The general/by-elections were held for five chairperson posts and 71 councillor posts in urban local bodies.

Of the 31,928 eligible voters, 27,006 exercised their franchise across 96 polling stations, resulting in a voter turnout of 84.58 per cent, according to an official statement.

First PM Awas in Bastar Division equipped with solar system

Under 'PM Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

RAIPUR: As part of the Sushasan Tihar initiative, Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai visited Gram Badeknera in Kondgaon district on Monday. He met Anand Kumar Pawar, a beneficiary of the Prime Minister Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana, at his residence to understand the scheme's positive impact on his family.

During the interaction, CM Sai learned how the welfare initiative has brought financial relief, energy self-reliance and renewed hope for a better future to the beneficiary's household.

Speaking with the Chief Minister, Anand Kumar Pawar, stated that his family's monthly electricity bill previously ranged between Rs 1,200

Uttar Pradesh just a year away, the BJP is looking forward to putting in place a full-fledged organisational team and sharpening its electoral strategy in the country's most politically significant state.

Uttar Pradesh, the country's most populous state, sends 80 Lok Sabha MPs and the state has 403 Assembly seats.

Sources said the top leadership also reviewed political developments related to a few other states where organisational and governmental adjustments are due.

The BJP is all set to undertake Cabinet expansions in Assam and West Bengal later this week, which will coincide with a broader round of political appointments.

The BJP has already

appointed Union minister Harsh Malhotra as the new president for Delhi state unit.

Significantly, Sunday's BJP CEC's meeting was held at the prime minister's residence. Normally it meets at party headquarters located on Deen Dayal Upadhyay Marg.

The meeting was also attended by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Union Home minister Amit Shah, BJP general secretary (organisation) BL Santhosh, and several members of the party's CEC.

The BJP's CEC normally meets to discuss candidates for Lok Sabha and state Assembly related discussions.

It is not very common for this high-powered body to discuss the candidates for the state legislative council of any state.

KARNATAKA POWER TRANSITION

DK & Siddaramaiah reach Delhi for Cabinet talks with Cong high command

NEW DELHI: Karnataka chief minister-designate D K Shivakumar and senior leader Siddaramaiah arrived in the national capital on Monday to hold consultations with the Congress high command over the composition of the new state Cabinet, ahead of the June 3 swearing-in ceremony.

Shivakumar, who replaces Siddaramaiah after being formally elected leader of the Congress Legislature Party in Karnataka on Saturday, is scheduled to be sworn in as the chief minister alongside select members of his council at 4:05 pm on Wednesday.

Asked about the visit, Shivakumar, who checked into Karnataka Bhawan here, told reporters, "We have to decide" -- a reference to the council of ministers.

Siddaramaiah, meanwhile,



Karnataka CM-designate DK Shivakumar being greeted by Congress leader B K Hariprasad during a meeting, in New Delhi, Monday **PTI**

is staying at a private hotel in the national capital. With Karnataka's council of ministers capped at 34 -- including the chief minister -- and a swelling pool of aspirants vying for limited berths, Shivakumar faces one of his first and most consequential tests as CM-designate. Party sources acknowledged

the risk of widespread disgruntlement among those who fail to make the cut.

Asked on Sunday about the number of ministers to be sworn in alongside him, Shivakumar said, "I don't know. Whatever the party high command decides will be done. I don't want to comment on that."

Aspirants have reached the national capital in numbers, with former ministers and legislators seeking audiences with both Shivakumar and Siddaramaiah to press their claims.

Party sources indicate the new Cabinet is likely to be a blend of familiar faces and fresh entrants, with careful attention paid to caste arithmetic, regional balance and loyalty equations -- particularly towards the Siddaramaiah camp. **MP08T**

AASU leader killed, sister injured in machete attack

NALBARI: In a case of unrequited love, a local All Assam Students' Union (AASU) leader was killed and his cousin sister critically injured in a machete attack by a teenager, who was later gunned down by police while trying to escape after his arrest in Nalbari district of Assam, officials said on Monday.

The attack on the duo took place in Gangapur village near Jagara on Sunday evening when they were returning home from Nalbari after purchasing some books, while the police action on the assailant happened at a 'char' (riverine island) in Mukalmua on Monday. **MP08T**

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Chandrachud S/o Sgt. Satish Singh, Resident of Village Fakana, P.O. Pitovas, District Bulandshahr, have changed my name from CHANDRACHUD to "CHANDRACHUD SINGH" vide affidavit dated 01/06/2026 at District Court, Bulandshahr

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Office of the Principal Chief Materials Manager
Headquarters Office, Baroda House, New Delhi-110001
No. 15235293A/P-15 Dt. 29.05.2026
Sub:- Intimation of Pre-bid meeting for procurement of Telescopic Boom Crane of minimum 175 T in news paper.
Tender No 15235293A for procurement of 08 Nos. of Telescopic Boom Crane of minimum 175 T has been published by this office. The pre-bid meeting as scheduled for 17.06.2026 in PCMM Conference Room, Stores Branch, Baroda House from 15:00 hrs onwards & tender is due to open on dated 21.07.2026.
Estimated Cost of Purchase is approx. Rs. 67.09 Crore. Please make it convenient to attend the pre-bid meeting.
This is your kind information please.
1851/26 DY.CMM/DSL
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE
Suryoday Small Finance Bank Limited
Regd. & Corp. office: 1101, Sharda Terraces, Plot 65, Sector - 11, CBD, Belapur, Navi Mumbai - 400614. CIN: L65923MH2008PLC261472.
POSESSION NOTICE
Whereas the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the M/s. Suryoday Small Finance Bank Ltd., under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (ACT NO.54 OF 2002) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a demand notice to below mentioned Borrower's / Guarantor's. After completion of 60 days from date of receipt of the said notice, The Borrower's / Guarantor's having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower's / Guarantor's and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on them under section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 6 & 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 on the date mentioned herewith:
Name of Borrower / Co-Borrower/ Guarantor Date of Demand Notice 08.11.2025
247000002027, 1. MR. NARESH C/O MAHENDER SINGH, 2. MRS. DIMPLE VERMA C/O NARESH Total Outstanding Amount in Rs. Rs. 19,68,977.16/- as on 04.11.2025
Date of Possession 30.05.2026(Physical)
Description Of Secured Asset(s)/Immovable Property (ies) : "All The Peace And Parcel Of Bearing Entire Upper Ground Floor Without Roof Lights, Built On Freehold Property Bearing Municipale No.2593/194, Old Plot No.109, Land Area Measuring 39 Sq. Yds. Approximately, Out Of Khasara No.229/1, Situated In The Area Of Village-Chowkri, Mubarakabad, Delhi State Delhi, Abadi Known As Onkar Nagar-A, Tri Nagar, New Delhi-110035, Boundaries Here Under:- East By: Road 20R, West By: Property No. 2592, North By: Property/Portion Of Mukli Gupta House, South By: Property/Portion Of Pushpakansal House."
The Borrower's / Guarantor's in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the M/s Suryoday Small Finance Bank Ltd. for an above mentioned demanded amount and further interest thereon.
Date: 02.06.2026, Place : New Delhi Authorised Officer, Suryoday Small Finance Bank Limited

ICICI Bank Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited, 3rd Floor Shal Tower, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, Delhi- 110005
PUBLIC NOTICE-TENDER CUM E-AUCTION FOR SALE OF SECURED ASSET
[See proviso to Rule 8(6)]
Notice for sale of immovable asset(s)
E-Auction Sale Notice for the sale of immovable asset(s) under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8 (6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.
This notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged/ charged to the Secured Creditor, the Physical Possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of ICICI Bank Limited will be sold on 'As is where is', 'As is what is' and 'Whatever there is' as per the brief particulars given hereunder;
Sr. No. Name of Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrowers/ Guarantors/ Loan Account No. Details of the Secured asset(s) with known encumbrances, if any Amount Outstanding Reserve Price Earnest Money Deposit Date and Time of Property Inspection Date & Time of E-Auction
(A) (B) (C) (D) (E) (F) (G)
1. Umesh Kumar Sharma (Applicant), Preeti Sharma (Co-Applcint) Lan No. LBDEL00001218560 MIG Flat No. S-4, With Roof Rights 2nd Floor, At Plot No. C-84, Block C, Shalimar Garden Ext-2, Village Pasonda, Ghaziabad. Admeasuring an Area of 650 Sq Ft Rs. 76,30,087/- As on May 25, 2026 Rs. 24,75, 000/- From To Rs. 2,47, 500/- 12.2026 June 24, 2026 04:00 PM 11:00 AM To 12:00 Noon
The online auction will take place on the website (URL Link-https://BidDeal.in) of e-auction agency Value Trust Capital Services Private Limited. The Mortgagors/ noticee are given a last chance to pay the total dues with Private Limited, 3. Motex Net Pvt. Ltd. 4. Finvin Estate Deal Technologies Pvt Ltd. 5. Gironsoft Pvt Ltd. 6. Hecto Prop Tech Pvt Ltd. 7. Arca Emart Pvt Ltd. 8. Novel Asset Service Pvt Ltd. 9. Nobroker Technologies Solutions Pvt Ltd. 10. Value Trust Capital Services Private Limited., have also been engaged for facilitating the sale of this property.
The Authorised Officer reserves the right to reject any or all the bids without furnishing any further reasons. For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please visit www.icicibank.com/n4p4s
Date: June 02, 2026 Place: Delhi & Ghaziabad
Authorized Officer, ICICI Bank Limited

SECURITY COOPERATION DISCUSSED IN HIGH-LEVEL TALKS

India, Australia push for freedom of navigation

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India and Australia on Monday underscored the importance of freedom of navigation, overflight and unimpeded maritime trade amid disruptions in energy supply chains following the West Asia crisis as well as concerns over China's increasing assertiveness in the Indo-Pacific.

These issues figured prominently during wide-ranging talks between Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and Australian Deputy Prime Minister Richard Marles in New Delhi. The two ministers affirmed the importance of enhancing cooperation with regional partners to help maintain a free, open, peaceful, stable and prosperous Indo-Pacific while emphasising the strategic importance of defence industrial collaboration and engagement between



Defence minister Rajnath Singh during a meeting with Australian Deputy PM Richard Marles, unseen, in New Delhi

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The issues figured prominently during wide-ranging talks between Defence minister Rajnath Singh and Australian Deputy PM Richard Marles in New Delhi
- » Singh and Marles also underlined the strategic importance of India-Australia defence industrial collaboration and engagement

India and Australia. Following the talks, Singh and Marles announced that the two countries would begin developing an MoU regarding the provision of defence articles and defence services as the next step in deepening defence industrial collaboration.

"The ministers discussed advancements in bilateral maritime security cooperation and efforts to finalise the Joint Maritime Security Collaboration Roadmap," a joint statement said. It said Singh and Marles agreed to progress the collaborative maritime domain

awareness activities by maritime patrol aircraft and explore opportunities to enhance undersea domain awareness.

"The ministers affirmed the importance of enhancing cooperation with regional partners to help maintain a free, open, peaceful, stable and prosper-

ous Indo-Pacific," according to the statement.

"The ministers underscored the importance of freedom of navigation and overflight, and their strong support for unimpeded trade in the region and other lawful uses of the sea consistent with international law, particularly the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS)," it said. Singh and Marles also underlined the strategic importance of India-Australia defence industrial collaboration and engagement and welcomed Canberra's first defence trade mission to India.

They agreed to explore further exchanges, including through the Joint Working Group on Defence Industry, Research, and Materiel.

The two ministers welcomed the growing strategic convergence between Austra-

lia, India, Japan and the United States in the Indo-Pacific and reaffirmed their commitment to enhancing collaboration on maritime domain awareness to increase interoperability among the partners.

Singh and Marles expressed strong support for the Quad Indo-Pacific Maritime Surveillance Collaboration (IPMSC) initiative, to be implemented initially in the Indian Ocean Region as well as through subject matter expert exchanges and tabletop exercises.

In a social media post, Singh described his meeting with Marles as "excellent". "Together we reviewed the full range of bilateral defence cooperation and discussed ways and means to enhance it further. The India-Australia Defence Partnership is poised to make steady progress in the years to come," he said.

PROBE DEEPENS

CBI to reconstruct Twisha death scene using 80-kg dummy

NARESH BISWANI

INSIGHT

- » Sources said mannequin will be weighed at the spot before the exercise
- » Investigators hope it will help determine whether the accounts given by those present at the time are consistent with the physical evidence and the layout of the residence

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) is preparing to carry out a detailed reconstruction of the events surrounding the death of former model and actress Twisha Sharma, who was found hanging at her residence in Bhopal's Bagmugalia area on May 12.

Investigators will use a dummy weighing nearly 80 kg, matching Twisha's approximate body weight, to recreate key aspects of the incident and verify statements made by the accused and witnesses.

Sources said the mannequin will be weighed at the spot before the exercise begins. The reconstruction will be conducted inside the house where Twisha died less than six months after her marriage. Investigators hope the exercise will help determine whether the accounts given by those present at the time are consistent with the physical evidence and the layout of the residence.

The CBI is expected to examine several crucial aspects, including the exact location where Twisha was allegedly found, the manner in which the ligature was removed, and the sequence of events that followed. The agency will also assess the positioning and movements of family members during the critical period. By recreating the circumstances under conditions similar to those on the day of the incident, investigators aim to test the feasibility of various claims and identify any inconsistencies.

Officials will compare the findings from the reconstruction with witness testimonies,

mobile phone records, digital evidence, video footage and forensic reports collected during the investigation. The exercise may also help establish a more accurate timeline regarding when the incident came to light and when Twisha was taken for medical assistance.

The development comes after the Madhya Pradesh High Court cancelled the anticipatory bail granted to Twisha's mother-in-law, Giribala Singh. While revoking the relief, the court took note of witness statements, digital communications, allegations linked to Twisha's pregnancy and medical reports indicating multiple injuries on her body before death.

Twisha, a former Miss Pune and MBA graduate who had been residing in Noida before her marriage, was found dead in her marital home. The initial post-mortem conducted at AIIMS Bhopal attributed the cause of death to asphyxia due to hanging. However, allegations of dowry harassment and possible tampering with evidence have raised serious questions about the circumstances leading to her death, which remain under investigation.

MP to implement UCC through dialogue with all sections: CM

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

BHOPAL: The Madhya Pradesh government has initiated the process of implementing the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) and will move forward through dialogue and consultation with all sections of society, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav said on Monday while announcing the constitution of a high-level committee headed by a former Supreme Court judge.

In a statement issued to the media, Yadav said the state government, under the guidance of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, was rapidly advancing towards implementation of the UCC while maintaining balance, dialogue and coordination among all communities. He said Madhya Pradesh was



among the most suitable states for introducing a uniform civil framework and reiterated the government's commitment to the welfare of all sections of society.

To encourage public participation, the state government has launched a dedicated website through which citizens can submit suggestions on the proposed legislation, he said.

The Chief Minister said a high-level committee compris-

ing experts and scholars from diverse fields has been constituted to examine the issue and gather public opinion. The panel will hold consultations across districts and seek suggestions from members of different religious communities before submitting its recommendations.

Yadav said the state government had decided to implement the UCC, arguing that separate customs and personal laws governing marriage and related matters across different religious communities were no longer necessary in the present era.

"The time has come for Madhya Pradesh to move towards a Uniform Civil Code," he said, adding that states such as Uttarakhand, Gujarat and Assam had already implemented similar provisions.

'HPCL commits fresh investments in Punjab's refinery, biogas sectors'

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann on Monday secured major investment commitments from Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited (HPCL), with the energy major announcing plans to expand its presence in the state through investments in refinery, biofuel and biogas projects.

During a meeting with HPCL Chairman Vikas Kaushal, Mann highlighted Punjab's strategic location, strong infrastructure, investor-friendly policies and transparent governance system, which he said have made the state one of North India's most attractive investment destinations.

The meeting also saw HPCL-Mittal Energy Limited (HMEI) announce plans

to further expand its operations in Punjab, particularly in the biofuel and biogas sectors. The proposed investments are expected to generate employment, strengthen the rural economy, support industrial growth and provide sustainable solutions for agricultural waste management. Mann informed the HPCL delegation about the state's governance reforms, including the Fast Track Punjab single-window system, which offers over 173 government-to-business services, auto-deemed approvals and time-bound clearances under the amended Punjab Right to Business Act.

"The vision of the Punjab Government is to make Punjab a preferred destination for global industry by offering policy stability,

speedy decision-making and an investor-friendly governance framework," the Chief Minister said. He noted that HPCL's interest in refinery and biogas projects would boost economic activity and create new employment opportunities for the state's youth. Mann also welcomed HMEI's expansion plans in Bathinda through second-generation (2G) technology, which aims to convert agricultural residue into biofuel.

The Chief Minister said HPCL is establishing 10 biogas plants across Punjab, of which five have already become operational. He said the projects would help tackle stubble management challenges while benefiting farmers and addressing environmental concerns. MPOST

Realtor held in Rs 645-cr IDFC First Bank 'fraud'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHANDIGARH: The Directorate of Enforcement (ED), Chandigarh Zonal Office, has arrested real estate businessman Vikram Wadhwa in connection with the alleged Rs 645-crore IDFC First Bank fraud case involving the misappropriation of government and institutional funds. Wadhwa was taken into custody on May 29 under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002.

According to the ED, its investigation has uncovered the alleged diversion and misuse of funds belonging to the Haryana Government, the Chandigarh Administration and two private schools located in Chandigarh and Panchkula. The agency claims that the funds were routed through accounts maintained with IDFC First Bank and subsequently siphoned off through a network of entities and individuals.

The ED has alleged that Wadhwa was a key conspirator in the fraud along with co-accused Ribhav Rishi, Abhay Kumar, certain bank officials and government functionaries. Investigators claim that he played an active role in generating, layering and concealing the proceeds of crime. More than Rs 70 crore was allegedly transferred directly into his personal bank accounts, while he is also accused of receiving substantial cash generated from the diverted funds. The agency alleged that illegally obtained money was routed through several firms linked to Wadhwa, including Capco Fintech Services, Swastik Desh Projects, R.S. Traders and SRR Planning Gurus Pvt. Ltd. Funds were allegedly moved through multiple bank accounts to obscure their origin before being used to acquire immovable assets.

The ED said its probe has also revealed transfers of hundreds of crores of rupees to jewellery firms through intermediary entities. Investigators suspect that large amounts of cash were generated through these transactions and distributed among various beneficiaries, including public servants and private individuals.

Tinsukia Division renews 10.61 km track in May: NFR



MALIGAON: Northeast Frontier Railway's (NFR) Tinsukia Division achieved a major milestone in infrastructure maintenance by completing 10.61 km of Through Sleeper Renewal work in the Moranh-Dibrugarh section during May 2026.

The renewal work was carried out using the Track Relaying Train machine and was completed through the effective utilisation of 21 traffic blocks, including nine night blocks. MPOST

CBI arrests former RCom Group MD Jhunjhunwala

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested Amitabh Jhunjhunwala, former Group Managing Director of Reliance Communications (RCom), in connection with an alleged bank fraud involving loans extended to companies of the Reliance Communications Group.

According to the agency, Jhunjhunwala played a key role in securing loans from a consortium of banks and in the subsequent deployment of funds.

The case stems from a complaint filed by State Bank of India (SBI) against Reliance Communications and its founder, Anil Ambani. SBI, which led a consortium of 11 banks, had sanctioned long-term credit facilities to the company. Following loan

defaults, the accounts turned non-performing assets (NPAs), resulting in alleged losses of about Rs 6,015 crore to lenders, including Rs 2,929.05 crore claimed by SBI.

The CBI said public sector banks had a total exposure of Rs 19,694.33 crore to Reliance Communications.

Jhunjhunwala was lodged in Delhi's Tihar Jail in an Enforcement Directorate case when the CBI secured a production warrant. After being declared fit to travel by AIIMS, New Delhi, he was brought to Mumbai on June 1 and formally arrested. He is currently lodged in Arthur Road Jail.

The arrest comes days after the CBI filed its first chargesheet naming 16 accused, including company and bank officials.

Chief Minister Nayab Saini launches 'Make in Haryana' Industrial Policy

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Monday launched the 'Make in Haryana Industrial Policy', setting an ambitious target of attracting investments worth Rs 5 lakh crore to transform the state into a leading manufacturing and investment hub. On the occasion, Memorandums of Understanding (MoUs) worth Rs 1.10 lakh crore were signed with investors. The CM also unveiled nine sector-specific industrial policies, an Intelligent Investment Facilitation Portal and the logo of the upcoming Happening Haryana Global Investors Summit.

Addressing industry leaders and investors, Saini said the new policy would strengthen Haryana's industrial ecosystem, simplify procedures and create new opportunities for economic growth. He said the policy is designed to position



Haryana as a preferred destination for future-ready manufacturing driven by innovation, sustainability, exports and employment generation.

Highlighting the changing global investment landscape, Saini said investors today look beyond incentives and evaluate factors such as governance, reliability, speed of decision-making and long-term growth potential. Haryana, he said, is well placed to meet these expectations. Calling the initiative a roadmap for the state's next

phase of economic development, he invited domestic and global investors to participate in Haryana's growth story and announced that the state would soon host the Haryana Global Investors Summit.

The chief minister noted that despite accounting for only 1.3 per cent of India's geographical area, Haryana contributes nearly 3.6 per cent to the country's GDP. He attributed the state's industrial success to its strong infrastructure, including expressways, freight corridors, rail connectivity, logistics hubs and proximity to the National Capital Region.

Saini also launched the Intelligent Investment Facilitation Portal, describing it as a major step towards smart governance. The portal will provide investors with a single-window platform for approvals, land allocation, incentives, compliances and clearances. MPOST

TB awareness prog held at Patna hospital

MPOST BUREAU

HAIJIPUR: As part of the Centre's "100-Day TB-Free India Campaign", Central Super Speciality Hospital, Patna, organised the fourth public awareness programme on Monday to educate people about tuberculosis and its prevention.

The event was held under the guidance of Medical Director Dr Subodh Kumar Mishra. Speaking on the occasion, Dr Manisha, a DNB student in Obstetrics and Gynaecology, highlighted the symptoms, diagnosis and treatment of Female Genital Tuberculosis and stressed the importance of early detection. Head of the Department of Obstetrics and Gynaecology Dr Sandhya Kiran also addressed participants on challenges associated with the disease. More than 250 patients and attendants attended the programme.

AMID GROWING FOOD SECURITY CONCERNS

Rising night temperatures threaten wheat yields in Uttar Pradesh: Study

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Rising night-time temperatures and shrinking winter seasons are posing a serious threat to wheat production in Uttar Pradesh, India's largest wheat-producing state, according to a new report released by climate research organisation Climate Trends.

The study, titled Wheat Under Stress: Climate Change, Rising Heat, and Adaptation Pathways in India's Major Wheat-Growing States, warns that warming winters, increasing minimum temperatures and recurring heat stress events are disrupting wheat cultivation across major producing states, including Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Haryana, Madhya Pradesh and Gujarat.

The findings come amid growing concerns over India's food security. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has recently revised its monsoon forecast downward to 90 per cent of the long-period average, while global weather agencies are monitoring conditions

KEY POINTS

- » According to the report, night-time temperatures are rising faster than daytime temperatures across major wheat-growing regions
- » UP recorded one of the steepest increases in minimum temperatures among the states studied



» Researchers said warmer nights increase plant respiration, causing crops to consume carbohydrates stored for grain development

that could develop into a strong El Niño event, raising fears of adverse impacts on agriculture.

India produces around 107 million tonnes of wheat annually and contributes nearly 14 per cent of global wheat output. Uttar Pradesh accounts for the largest share of the country's wheat production, making climate-related risks in the state particularly significant.

According to the report, night-time temperatures are rising faster than daytime temperatures across major wheat-growing regions. Uttar Pradesh recorded one of the steepest

increases in minimum temperatures among the states studied. Researchers said warmer nights increase plant respiration, causing crops to consume carbohydrates stored for grain development. This leads to premature maturity, reduced grain size and lower yields.

"One of the most under-recognised threats to India's wheat production is the steady increase in night-time temperatures," said Dr Palak Balyan, Research Lead at Climate Trends and lead author of the study. She noted that warmer nights create physiological stress in plants, while

sudden warming during February and March shortens the grain-filling period critical for yield formation.

The report found that winters are becoming shorter, with February warming at a rate of 0.69 degrees Celsius per decade. March and April have also recorded significant temperature increases, exposing wheat crops to heat stress during sensitive growth stages such as flowering and grain filling.

The study also highlights the growing risk from unseasonal rainfall linked to delayed western disturbances. Heavy rains during March and April often coincide with harvesting, damaging standing crops, reducing grain quality and increasing post-harvest losses.

Experts said farmers are responding by altering sowing schedules, adopting heat-tolerant and short-duration varieties and improving water management practices. However, limited access to finance, technology and climate information continues to constrain adaptation efforts.

An Ode to Dust

PK MISHRA

Truth and sermons have a curious habit of returning. They come back quietly, hold up a mirror, and confront you with uncomfortable accuracy.

These days, I encounter that truth every morning.

During my service years, I routinely lectured officers on maintaining clean workplaces. A swipe of my finger across a surface would reveal a tiny speck of dust, which I would present as evidence while delivering another sermon on cleanliness, discipline and the war against dirt. The officer standing beside me would carefully attempt to locate the microscopic exhibit and nod gravely, as though together we had uncovered proof of a national conspiracy.

Across four decades, posts, responsibilities and people changed. One thing remained constant: dust. I inspected coaches, stations, workshops and yards with missionary zeal. Faces changed, but garbage displayed a permanence and institutional continuity that many organisations might well have envied.

Perhaps dust listened carefully to all my lectures, because after retirement it returned for revenge.

The white tiles in my house began exposing every speck, stain and smudge. I soon realised that white tiles are not flooring; they are moral instruments. My old lectures came back to haunt me. One moment I would be working at the computer, the next I would find myself staring at a stain.

Finally, I picked up a mop.

Then came a deeper realisation: the more I cleaned, the more conspicuous the remaining smudge became. Perfection, it seemed, recedes



as one approaches it.

During service, I believed cleanliness was a management issue, solvable through inspections and supervision. Retirement taught me otherwise. Dust is eternal. Civilisations rise and fall, governments change, officers retire, technologies evolve — but dust survives with quiet confidence.

Human beings merely negotiate temporary settlements with disorder. Every morning we sweep, wipe and organise our little corners of existence, only to find that by evening entropy has resumed possession. Perhaps that is why saints preach detachment. Attachment often begins innocently enough with white tiles and ends up consuming an afternoon.

Yet every morning I continue my battle with mop and cloth, not because I expect victory, but because resisting chaos, however briefly, lends meaning to civilised life. And, of course, because guests may suddenly arrive.

(Edited excerpt from the article written by PK Mishra of Modern Coach Factory, Raebareilly)

EDITORIAL
BEYOND OIL

The coming into force of the India-Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) on June 1 marks another significant milestone in India's evolving trade diplomacy. It is the fifth major trade pact implemented under the Narendra Modi government, following agreements with Mauritius, Australia, the UAE and the European Free Trade Association bloc. While trade agreements often attract attention primarily for tariff reductions, the India-Oman CEPA is far more consequential. It reflects India's broader strategy of diversifying export markets, strengthening economic partnerships across the Gulf region, and positioning itself more deeply within global supply chains. At a time when protectionist tendencies continue to surface in many parts of the world, India's willingness to negotiate comprehensive market-access agreements demonstrates confidence in its economic competitiveness. More importantly, this agreement comes with a strategic dimension that extends beyond commerce. Oman occupies a critical geographical position near the Strait of Hormuz, through which a substantial share of the world's energy supplies passes. Strengthening economic integration with Muscat therefore serves both commercial and geopolitical objectives.

The immediate economic benefits are substantial. India will receive virtually complete duty-free access to the Omani market, covering more than 98 per cent of tariff lines and nearly the entire value of bilateral trade. For Indian exporters, particularly in sectors such as textiles, engineering goods, automobiles, processed food, pharmaceuticals, gems and jewellery, the removal of tariffs offers a significant competitive advantage. Many of these products currently face a five per cent import duty in Oman, a seemingly modest barrier that nevertheless affects price competitiveness in a highly contested market. The agreement also creates opportunities in sectors such as chemicals, machinery, plastics, minerals and precision instruments. Equally significant is the fact that all major tariff concessions become effective from the first day of implementation, ensuring that businesses can begin benefiting immediately. For a country that seeks to increase its merchandise exports and generate employment through manufacturing expansion, such preferential access to overseas markets is invaluable.

Perhaps the most forward-looking aspect of the agreement lies in services and professional mobility. India's services exports to Oman have grown steadily over the past decade, driven by information technology, telecommunications, transport and travel services. Yet India still accounts for only a small share of Oman's total services imports, indicating substantial untapped potential. The CEPA seeks to address this gap by providing stronger commitments on the temporary movement of professionals. For the first time in any free trade agreement signed by Oman, specific commitments have been made for professionals in fields such as engineering, information technology, healthcare, education, accounting and consulting. The increase in the ceiling for intra-corporate transferees will also help Indian firms deploy managerial and specialist talent more efficiently. Given India's strengths in human capital and knowledge-intensive services, these provisions could ultimately prove more valuable than tariff concessions on goods. They align with India's long-term ambition of becoming not merely a manufacturing hub but also a leading global provider of services and skilled professionals.

The agreement is also noteworthy for what it excludes. Trade liberalisation often generates concerns about the vulnerability of domestic industries and farmers. Recognising these sensitivities, India has carefully protected key sectors by placing thousands of tariff lines on an exclusion list. Agriculture, dairy products, cereals, edible oils, meat products and several sensitive manufacturing sectors remain shielded from unrestricted competition. Such calibrated liberalisation reflects a pragmatic approach to trade policy. Rather than embracing free trade unconditionally, India is attempting to balance export promotion with domestic economic stability. This approach is particularly important in a country where millions of livelihoods remain dependent on agriculture and small-scale manufacturing. By combining market access with strategic safeguards, policymakers have sought to maximise gains while minimising disruption.

Ultimately, the India-Oman CEPA should be viewed not as an isolated agreement but as part of a larger strategic shift. India has already deepened economic integration with the UAE, concluded negotiations with the United Kingdom and New Zealand, and is pursuing broader engagement with the Gulf Cooperation Council and the European Union. Oman, though relatively small in economic size, serves as an important gateway to the wider Middle East and parts of Africa. Nearly seven lakh Indians live and work in Oman, contributing significantly to both economies through trade, investment and remittances. In an era when economic partnerships increasingly shape geopolitical influence, agreements such as the CEPA help create durable networks of interdependence and trust. For India, the challenge now lies not in signing agreements but in ensuring that businesses, exporters and professionals fully utilise the opportunities they create. If implemented effectively, the India-Oman CEPA could become a model for how trade policy advances economic growth, strategic interests and regional connectivity simultaneously.

NATURE'S
BALANCE



SINGARAM
KULANDAIVEL

THE WRITER
IS THE CHIEF
CONSERVATOR
OF FORESTS,
WEST BENGAL

From the Sundarbans to the Himalayas, India remains one of the few places where wildlife survives alongside people

URGENT
REFORMS



VK BAHUGUNA

THE WRITER IS A
FORMER PRINCIPAL
SECRETARY, GOVT
OF TRIPURA
AND CHAIRMAN
OF CENTRE
FOR RESOURCE
MANAGEMENT AND
ENVIRONMENT

CGHS serves more than 45 lakh central government employees, pensioners, and dependants, yet it continues to struggle with outdated infrastructure and cumbersome processes

Living With the Wild

India's conservation future lies not in separating people and wildlife, but in learning how both can share an increasingly crowded landscape



The future of Indian conservation will depend on reimagining how both can continue to share the same land

India is not merely a nation of villages, megacities, rivers, mountains, and monsoons. It is one of the world's last great shared landscapes, where humans and wildlife coexist amid extraordinary demographic pressure. From the elephant corridors of Northeast India to the tiger forests of Central India, from the leopard-inhabited sugarcane belts of Maharashtra to the mangrove islands of the Sundarbans, the story of India is also the story of coexistence — fragile, complex, often dangerous, yet profoundly remarkable.

No other major nation on Earth supports such enormous populations of both humans and megafauna within the same living landscape. India holds nearly 18 per cent of the world's human population on only about 2.4 per cent of the global land area, yet it supports almost 8 per cent of global biodiversity.

The country shelters around 3,682 tigers, over 32,000 Asian elephants, the world's only population of Asiatic lions, one-horned rhinoceroses, snow leopards, gaurs, wolves, bears, and thousands of lesser-known species spread across forests, wetlands, deserts, grasslands, mountains, coasts, and agricultural landscapes. According to the India State of Forest Report 2023, forest and tree cover together account for approximately 25.17 per cent of the country's geographical area. India today has 107 national parks, over 573 wildlife sanctuaries, 58 tiger reserves, 33 elephant reserves, 18 Biosphere Reserves, and numerous eco-sensitive zones. Yet the reality of modern conservation is that wildlife no longer remains confined within these protected boundaries.

In the Himalayan states of Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh, leopards frequently enter villages and semi-urban settlements. In Assam and North Bengal, elephant herds migrate through densely populated tea estates and agricultural fields. In Karnataka, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu, elephants and gaurs cross highways, plantations, and settlements. In Maharashtra, leopards have demonstrated astonishing adaptability by surviving and breeding in sugarcane fields near villages.

Around Sanjay Gandhi National Park, leopards continue to survive in one of the world's most densely populated metropolitan regions. In Gujarat, Asiatic lions roam well beyond protected forests across agro-pastoral landscapes, creating one of the world's rare examples where large carnivores coexist within human-dominated environments.

Yet coexistence is not always peaceful. Every year across India, hundreds of people lose their lives in encounters with elephants, leopards, tigers, bears, and other wildlife. Thousands of hectares of crops are damaged, while livestock losses create severe economic

hardship for vulnerable rural families. Equally tragic are wildlife deaths caused by train collisions, electrocution, poisoning, retaliatory killings, road accidents, habitat degradation, and poaching. The emotional trauma faced by families affected by conflict often remains invisible within mainstream conservation discourse. The farmer guarding crops throughout the night under fear of elephant raids, the widow of a forest-fringe villager killed by wildlife, the forest frontline staff responding to emergencies in difficult terrain, and the exhausted elephant herd searching for food and water in fragmented forests are all victims of the same ecological imbalance.

At the heart of this crisis lies landscape fragmentation. India's forests once formed vast, interconnected ecosystems, allowing animals to migrate freely across regions in response to water, food, breeding routes, and seasonal movement patterns developed over centuries. Today, many of these natural corridors have become fragmented by highways, railway tracks, mining belts, irrigation canals, industries, transmission lines, urban expansion, and agricultural encroachments. Ecologists describe this phenomenon as habitat fragmentation, where once-connected ecosystems become isolated ecological islands. Such fragmentation reduces landscape connectivity, interrupts migration routes, and increases risks of genetic bottlenecks within wildlife populations.

Elephants perhaps illustrate this crisis most vividly. India currently has more than 150 identified elephant corridors, many of which are heavily fragmented or encroached upon. Elephants are landscape species requiring large connected habitats and following ancient migratory routes led by experienced matriarchs. When these corridors are blocked, herds are forced through villages, agricultural fields, railway lines, and roads, dramatically escalating conflict. In the Southwest Bengal

landscape, elephants moving through the Dalmá-Mayurjharna-Bankura-Jhargram belt regularly interact with densely populated settlements. Similarly, in North Bengal and Assam, elephant movement through tea estates has become an integral yet risky part of regional ecology.

Climate change is now intensifying these pressures further. Increasing droughts, prolonged heat waves, erratic rainfall, shrinking water sources, cyclones, forest fires, and changing vegetation patterns are altering wildlife behaviour across India. In dry deciduous forests of Central and Southern India, severe summer water scarcity often pushes elephants, deer, and carnivores towards villages and agricultural landscapes. In the Himalayan region, changing snowfall patterns and warming temperatures are influencing herbivore movement and predator-prey relationships. In the Sundarbans, rising sea levels, cyclones, and salinity intrusion threaten both wildlife habitat and human survival simultaneously.

The Sundarbans perhaps represent one of the world's most dramatic examples of shared ecological survival. Here, mangrove forests, tigers, fishermen, honey collectors, tidal rivers, cyclones, and climate vulnerability exist within the same fragile landscape. Human communities survive amidst constant risks from storms, erosion, tiger encounters, and salinity intrusion, while wildlife simultaneously struggles against shrinking habitat and climate instability. The Sundarbans are not merely a tiger landscape; they are a living illustration of how climate change, biodiversity conservation, and human vulnerability are becoming inseparably interconnected.

Yet India's conservation story is not merely a narrative of conflict between humans and wildlife; it is also a powerful story of resilience, adaptation, and coexistence deeply embedded in the country's cultural and ecological history.

This ecological wisdom later evolved into modern participatory conservation models such as Joint Forest Management. One of India's most influential experiments emerged from the Arabari forests of West Bengal during the 1970s, where degraded sal forests were successfully regenerated through community participation. Today, thousands of Forest Protection Committees, Eco-Development Committees, women's self-help groups, and JFM Committees actively participate in habitat restoration, anti-poaching, fire prevention, and conflict mitigation, proving that conservation succeeds best when communities become stakeholders rather than outsiders.

Conservation is ultimately about securing ecological stability itself. Forests regulate rainfall, recharge groundwater, stabilise soil, absorb carbon, moderate climate, and support pollinators essential for agriculture. Wildlife species maintain ecosystem balance through seed dispersal, nutrient cycling, grazing regulation, and food-chain stability. The destruction of biodiversity ultimately weakens agriculture, water security, climate resilience, and public health. Conservation is therefore not separate from human survival; it is central to it.

India's future conservation strategy must increasingly adopt landscape ecology rather than isolated protected-area thinking. Wildlife moves beyond administrative boundaries; therefore, conservation must also expand beyond maps. Farms, riverbanks, tea gardens, mangroves, grazing lands, urban green spaces, village commons, and degraded landscapes all form part of the broader ecological network sustaining biodiversity.

Equally important is justice for forest-fringe communities. Communities bearing the direct costs of conservation deserve timely compensation, crop insurance, access to healthcare, livelihood diversification, education, and participation in decision-making. Delayed compensation and exclusion from conservation planning often generate resentment and mistrust. Coexistence can survive only when both people and wildlife are protected with dignity.

The future of Indian conservation will depend not on separating humans from nature, but on reimagining how both can continue to share the same land on an increasingly crowded planet. In the age of climate change, ecological decline, and expanding human pressure, India may ultimately offer the world one of its most important environmental lessons: survival will depend not on domination over nature, but on learning how humanity and wildlife can coexist within the same shared landscape with balance, resilience, and mutual survival.

Views expressed are personal

Trapped in a Bureaucratic Nightmare

Air India retirees and thousands of CGHS beneficiaries are facing delayed claims, hospital refusals and a healthcare system mired in administrative inefficiency



Systemic flaws within CGHS are leaving elderly beneficiaries vulnerable when they need care most

As India pushes towards universal health coverage under Ayushman Bharat, one of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's most significant welfare initiatives, another flagship healthcare scheme — the Central Government Health Scheme (CGHS) — is failing thousands of its most vulnerable beneficiaries. Senior citizens who served the national carrier Air India for decades are now caught in a web of red tape, delayed payments, and hospital harassment that has turned a promised seamless medical safety net into a source of constant anxiety and financial distress. Worse, complaints often appear to go unheard. Following the 2022 privatisation of Air India and its transfer to the Tata Group, the Government of India rightly extended CGHS benefits to eligible retired and retiring employees as a social safeguard. Official memoranda assured cashless treatment, medicines, and investigations at empanelled hospitals — benefits meant to replace or improve upon the earlier Retired Employees Medical Scheme (REMS). Yet, on the ground, the reality is starkly different. Many of these pensioners, now in their 70s and 80s, are forced to pay huge sums upfront for treatment and then chase reimbursements for months, often receiving only partial payments or facing outright claim rejections. The root of much of this suffering is an unnecessary detour through UTI Infrastructure Technology and Services Limited (UTIITSL), which has been appointed as the Bill Clearing Agency (BCA) for Air India-related CGHS claims. Instead of routing everything through the efficient National Health Authority (NHA) system that handles the main CGHS operations, these beneficiaries have been pushed into a parallel and significantly slower process.

A glaring example is Indresh Hospital in Dehradun, which has reportedly faced difficulties with UTIITSL for the last two months.

Despite submitting its valid NABH accreditation certificate six times, claims continue to be rejected, and the accreditation has allegedly not been recognised. Even a formal complaint lodged on the PMO grievance portal was dismissed, further eroding trust in the system. This has forced the hospital to either demand full cash payments from Air India retirees or turn them away, directly affecting patients in Uttarakhand and neighbouring regions. The Additional Director of CGHS is not authorised to supervise these matters, and even after official communication from his office, UTIITSL reportedly remains unresponsive. Hospitals across India — from Delhi and Mumbai to Chennai — empanelled under CGHS report similar difficulties. Bills are rejected on minor technical grounds, accreditation certificates are questioned despite NABH compliance, and payments are delayed by eight to eighteen months. As a result, several hospitals have either stopped providing cashless services to Air India cardholders or begun demanding full payment in advance. One affected retiree from Delhi described the ordeal: "We served the nation's airline through its toughest times. Now, in old age, we stand outside hospital counters begging for basic dignity in healthcare." Similar stories

are emerging from Mumbai, Kolkata, Chennai, and smaller cities where Air India employees settled after retirement. In many Tier-2 locations, empanelled facilities are already limited, and those that remain are increasingly reluctant to participate because of the UTIITSL bottleneck.

Systemic failures are plaguing CGHS. The problems extend far beyond Air India beneficiaries. CGHS serves more than 45 lakh central government employees, pensioners, and dependants, yet it continues to struggle with outdated infrastructure and cumbersome processes. Hospital empanelment remains inadequate, particularly outside metropolitan centres. CGHS package rates for surgeries and procedures have not kept pace with inflation or rising private healthcare costs, prompting many reputed hospitals either to opt out of the scheme altogether or to provide only limited services to CGHS patients. Claim settlements are notoriously slow. Although digital portals exist, they are often not user-friendly, forcing many elderly beneficiaries to submit physical documents and respond repeatedly to queries regarding formatting, signatures, or missing stamps. Advanced treatments frequently face reimbursement caps or exclusions, leaving patients to bear substantial

out-of-pocket expenses from their modest pensions. For Air India retirees, the situation is compounded by confusion over entitlement cards. Many received yellow-strip cards meant for autonomous bodies instead of the promised special-category cards. Entitlements are often not clearly printed, leading to disputes at hospital counters. While OPD services through CGHS wellness centres function relatively smoothly, inpatient department (IPD) treatment, day-care procedures, diagnostics, and emergency care have been severely affected by the UTIITSL routing mechanism.

This detour appears to contradict the original directives that envisioned seamless integration with the NHA platform. The result is a classic example of sound policy intent being undermined by poor implementation. Hospitals, already operating on thin margins under CGHS rates, are now burdened with endless administrative exchanges with UTIITSL, prompting many to either refuse treatment or insist on upfront payments. Families are being forced to sell assets or borrow money to finance medical care while waiting for reimbursements that may never arrive in full. This raises serious questions about the government's commitment to the welfare of employees from disinvested public sector enterprises. If a long-established scheme such as CGHS, backed by a dedicated budget and administrative framework, cannot deliver basic cashless healthcare efficiently, it becomes difficult to inspire confidence in the expansion of even more ambitious public health programmes.

Growing frustration has led to petitions reaching various High Courts, including notices reportedly issued by the Madras High Court in related matters. Retirees' associations have repeatedly written to the Ministries of Health, Civil Aviation, and Finance, highlighting what they see as violations of ear-

lier assurances. CGHS now requires bold, time-bound action rather than incremental adjustments. The most immediate step should be the removal of the UTIITSL layer for Air India beneficiaries and their complete integration into the NHA platform. NHA's experience in managing large-scale digital processing under PM-JAY could enable settlements within 30 to 45 days, restore hospital confidence, and ensure genuine cashless treatment. Second, CGHS rates must be revised annually through a transparent medical inflation index linked to NABH standards, while coverage should be expanded to include modern therapies without arbitrary caps. Empanelment drives should target at least 1,000 additional hospitals in Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities. Third, comprehensive digital transformation is long overdue. Auto-approval for high-compliance claims and penalties for clearing agencies that delay payments beyond 60 days would introduce much-needed accountability. Fourth, all retirees should receive standardised CGHS cards with lifelong validity and clearly defined entitlements. Finally, the government should consider establishing a dedicated medical corpus for these beneficiaries and explore convergence with other schemes to provide hybrid coverage. CGHS was envisioned as a model of dignified healthcare for public servants. Today, it risks becoming a symbol of bureaucratic indifference. The suffering of Air India retirees, exemplified by cases such as Indresh Hospital in Dehradun, along with the broader challenges facing the scheme, deserves national attention. The media, civil society, and policymakers must push for reforms that place patients — especially senior citizens — at the centre of the healthcare system. The government must act decisively to repair CGHS before more lives are compromised by avoidable administrative hurdles.

Views expressed are personal

IRAN HAS MAINTAINED ITS CHOKEHOLD ON HORMUZ

US bombs Iranian military sites, Kuwait hit by drone, missile fire

DUBAI: The United States said Monday that it bombed radar and drone sites in Iran after Tehran shot down an American drone over the weekend. Iran then said it targeted American soldiers in Kuwait with missiles, which the US says it shot down.

The nominal ceasefire between Iran and the US has been repeatedly tested with such back-and-forth attacks, even as officials from both countries try to negotiate an end to the war. It's not clear how close they are to a deal — and there is always the risk that an attack could derail those talks.

In the meantime, Iran has maintained its chokehold on the Strait of Hormuz, disrupting global energy supplies and driving up the price of fuel around the world, with far-reaching consequences. A cargo ship came under attack off Iraq Monday afternoon, the British military said.

Fighting has also escalated between Israel and the Lebanese militant group Hezbollah, despite their nominal ceasefire. Israel has extended its occupation deep into Lebanon, and Hezbollah — which joined the war in support of its main



The attacks represent the latest escalation between the US and Iran

backer, Iran — continues to launch drones into Israel.

The US military's Central Command said it carried out the strikes in Iran on Saturday and Sunday around the city of Geruk and on Qeshm Island, hitting air defences, a ground control station and two attack drones it said threatened ships in the region.

“The measured and delib-

“US FIGHTER AIRCRAFT SWIFTLY RESPONDED BY ELIMINATING IRANIAN AIR DEFENCES”

erate strikes occurred ... in response to aggressive Ira-

nian actions that included the shutdown of a US MQ-1 drone that was operating over international waters,” Central Command said.

Traffic through the Strait of Hormuz is at a trickle compared to before the war, with ship owners deterred by the risk of an Iranian attack. Only 36 ships transited the waterway in the seven days leading up to to Friday, a third of them carrying crude oil or petroleum products, according to Lloyd's List Intelligence.

That compares to an average of more than 130 ships per day before the war began.

Kuwait said its air defences opened fire early Monday morning to intercept incoming drone and missile fire.

Around the same time, Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard said it responded to an American attack without saying where, likely referring to the attack on Kuwait. In a statement carried by the state-run IRNA news agency, the Guard said that US forces had targeted a telecommunications tower.

Kuwait is home to US Army Central, the Mid-east forward command for the Army.

‘US forces guide 70 commercial ships through Strait of Hormuz’

Strait is the shipping route for 20% of global oil supplies

WASHINGTON: US armed forces have guided around 70 commercial ships over the past three weeks through the Strait of Hormuz, which remains a risky waterway since the US war with Iran began over three months ago, according to a media report.

US Central Command has guided around 70 commercial ships through the strait, travelling into and out of the Persian Gulf, in the last three weeks, the New York Times reported quoting US officials.

They said that most of the vessels had turned off their transponders to avoid detection when going through the narrow waterway.

Before the war broke out on February 28, over 100 commercial ships traversed through the Strait of Hormuz per day. The strait, a narrow waterway with Iran and Oman on either side, is the shipping route for 20 per cent of the global oil supplies.

The officials declined to say what type of vessels were going through and what route they took, but one official indicated that at least one route was not close to the Iranian coastline.

Ships passing near Iran without obtaining Iranian approval face the threat of an almost-certain attack by Ira-



Representational Image

Highlights

- » Before war broke out on February 28, over 100 commercial ships traversed through Strait of Hormuz per day
- » The US and Iran agreed to a ceasefire on April 8, but the Strait of Hormuz continues to be blocked by Tehran

nian drones or missiles, US officials said.

Shipping analysts say the US-guided crossings appear to follow routes that are closer to Oman.

And because US-guided

crossings take place with transponders turned off, known as “dark” passages, shipping analysts say they cannot independently verify how many may have taken place.

The US and Iran are negotiating an agreement to end the war that has disrupted global oil supplies, leading to high retail prices for petroleum products and fertilisers.

The US and Iran agreed to a ceasefire on April 8, but the Strait of Hormuz continues to be blocked by Tehran, which is asserting control over the waterway.

The US has enforced a blockade of the strait to disallow any ship movement towards Iran.

Confirmed Ebola cases in Congo reach 282

BUNIA: At least 282 confirmed cases of Ebola have now been reported in Congo's ongoing outbreak, the central African nation said late Sunday, as patients who recovered from the disease spoke of their indescribable joy in interviews with The Associated Press.

The outbreak remains focused in Congo's eastern Ituri province, where 264 of the cases have been recorded, Congo's Ministry of Health said. Congo has reported over 1,000 suspected cases with the Bundibugyo virus, the current species of Ebola, which has no approved treatment or vaccine.

According to the health ministry, the main challenges in containing the outbreak include early detection and rapid isolation of cases, rigorous contact tracing, safe and dignified burials and strengthening infection prevention and control in health facilities.

The contact tracing coverage rate so far is 45% with 220 suspected cases under investigation, the ministry said.

Meanwhile, some of the five people who have so far recovered from the disease spoke of their relief in interviews with The Associated Press.

Baraka Bulambulu, a nurse, said he was overjoyed after the last two Ebola tests on him returned negative.

Indian-origin pilot killed in US crash hours after wedding

NEW YORK: Two Indian-origin persons, including a newly-wed groom, have tragically died in a helicopter crash in Georgia, according to media reports.

Dave Fiji and his bride Jesni had boarded a Robinson R66 helicopter, piloted by Nikhil Nargundkar, bound for DeKalb-Peachtree Airport after the couple's wedding on Friday evening, a report in wrdw.com news portal said.

However, shortly after take-off, the helicopter crashed amid bad weather.

Dave, 26, and Nargundkar died in the crash near the Dawsonville wedding venue.

Jesni, 25, survived the crash and is currently undergoing treatment at a local Atlanta hospital.

A report in Atlanta News First identified the pilot of the helicopter as Nargundkar.

Malaysia bans under-16s from social media

Companies that fail to comply could face penalties of up to 10 million ringgit

KUALA LUMPUR: Malaysia on Monday began enforcing rules barring millions of children younger than 16 from having social media accounts, joining a global effort to tighten online safety protections for young users.

The rules require social media platforms with at least 8 million users including Facebook, Instagram, TikTok and YouTube, to implement age-verification systems and block users under 16 from creating accounts.

The regulator said the rules are not intended to prevent children from accessing digital technology

Malaysia's Communications and Multimedia Commission said Monday that age verification for existing users will be rolled out progressively

over the next six months.

Users identified as under 16 will have a month to download or transfer their data, including photos and videos, before any restrictions, suspensions, or other actions are applied, it said in a statement.

Companies that fail to comply could face penalties of up to 10 million ringgit (\$2.5 million). But parents whose children manage to bypass the law will not be penalised.

The government said the measures are aimed

at protecting children from harmful content, cyber-bullying and platform features designed to encourage excessive use.

Other countries including Australia, Brazil and Indonesia have introduced or announced age-based restrictions or requirements for children's access to social media. Countries including Britain, France, Spain, Denmark, Thailand and South Korea are also studying or developing similar approaches.

Israel orders strikes on Beirut's southern suburbs

BEIRUT: Israel's government ordered strikes on the southern suburbs of Beirut on Monday, a day after its ground forces reached their deepest point in Lebanon in 26 years and as Hezbollah fired rockets at northern Israel including the outskirts of coastal city of Haifa.

A joint statement by Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and Defence Minister Israel Katz said that following what they called

repeated violations of the ceasefire by Hezbollah and the “attacks against our cities and citizens,” they have ordered the Israeli military to attack targets in Beirut's southern suburbs known in Arabic as Dahiyeh.

Hezbollah agreed to halt attacks on Israel when the ceasefire was signed in April but resumed following Israeli strikes in Lebanon that Israel characterised as self-defence.

Sport

Tiebreak triumph sends Kalinskaya into quarterfinals

PARIS: Anna Kalinskaya of Russia made it to the quarterfinals of the French Open for the first time by defeating Anastasia Potapova of Austria 6-4, 2-6, 7-6 (10-7) on Monday.

Their contest on Court Suzanne-Lenglen stretched to almost three hours after Potapova failed to serve out the match twice in the decider and Kalinskaya overturned a 4-1 deficit in the super tiebreak.

It will be 22nd-ranked Kalinskaya's second quarterfinal at a major after she advanced that deep at the 2024 Australian Open.

Despite pre-tournament men's favorite Jannik Sinner losing in the second round, Italian fans will have at least one player in the quarterfinals.

Tenth-seeded Flavio Cobolli advanced to the sec-



Anna Kalinskaya beat Anastasia Potapova 6-4 2-6 7-6 (10-7)

ond Grand Slam quarterfinal of his career — and also his first here — after beating American Zachary Svajda 6-2, 6-3, 7-6 (3), 7-6 (5).

Vallejo fined \$65,000

Adolfo Daniel Vallejo was

fined \$65,000 after he said his second-round match should not have been umpired by a woman, organizers announced on Monday.

Vallejo lost to French teenager Moise Kouame last week after a tense five-set battle that lasted nearly five hours. He later told the tennis website Clay that “this sort of match needs to be umpired by a man.”

Following his 6-3, 7-5, 3-6, 2-6, 7-6 (8) loss, Vallejo added: “It's very difficult for a woman to do it.”

Players reaching the second round at the French Open receive \$151,000. Roland Garros director Amelie Mauresmo told reporters at the French Open that “a 65,000 euros” fine was handed down to the player, “representing roughly half of his prize money.”

Flower makes RCB bloom, again

RCB's quiet genius is the architect behind the team's revolution

AHMEDABAD: Accolades have been pouring in for Virat Kohli, Rajat Patidar and Bhuvneshwar Kumar for helping Royal Challengers Bengaluru lift their second IPL title on the bounce, but another man might be having a soft chuckle of satisfaction in a quiet corner.

Andy Flower — the silent revolutionary who transformed RCB from history-seekers to history-makers.

When he took over the reins in August 2023, RCB were still searching for their first IPL title, leaving them a target for merciless social media trolls.

It would not be an exaggeration to think that the Royal Challengers then were the Paris St Germain of the IPL, a team thriving on Galacticos culture.

Just like the PSG, now two-time UEFA Champions League winners under Luis Enrique, the Royal Challengers too went through years of disappointment despite assembling a glittering array of stars.

Along with Kohli, they had some of the best in T20 business such as AB de Villiers, Chris Gayle, Dale Steyn, Shane Watson, Yuvraj Singh etc.

Similar to PSG finding their Messiah in Enrique in 2023, the same year as Flower joined the Bengaluru side, RCB found theirs in the Zimbabwean — a



Andy Flower, Virat Kohli and Mo Babat pose with the trophy

no-nonsense cricketing brain who believes in structure and cohesion to bring in desired results. Flower came with proven multi-level credentials, having guided England to the Ashes in 2005, a Test series win in India (2012) and the 2010 T20 World Cup.

At the club level, he had orchestrated the title wins for Multan Sultans, Gulf Giants, Trent Rockets and Maratha Arabians in various franchise leagues. It mirrored Enrique's treble-winning success with Barcelona, and ending PSG's

55-year wait for an European crown. But for all that, Flower needed to break the set patterns in the Royal Challengers establishment.

Once he took over from Mike Hesson, Flower's concentration was to fortify RCB's bowling, yet, the signing of Bhuvneshwar Kumar ahead of IPL 2025 for Rs 10.75 crore raised a lot of eyebrows.

But it proved a masterstroke as the veteran pacer amassed 45 wickets across two IPL seasons, leading RCB's bowling unit with aplomb.

3

RCB became only the third team in the IPL to defend their title, joining CSK in 2011 and MI in 2020

Flower, a known supporter of young talents, worked along with mentor Dinesh Karthik, Director of Cricket Mo Bobat and a slew of scouts to rope in some young bowlers like Rasikh Salam Dhar, Suyash Sharma, Abhinandan Singh and Mangesh Yadav.

Skipper Patidar stressed on Flower's ability to work effectively with seasoned stars and upcoming talents. “I can say I have played for four years in the IPL. He is one of the best coaches, I feel, because of the way he handles players. Not only players who are playing, but the players who are not playing, the new players, those are playing their first IPL season. I don't have enough words for him, but he is the best coach I have played under,” gushed Patidar.

No victory parade

BENGALURU: The passionate fans will not be able to celebrate Royal Challengers Bengaluru's title defence with the team after the franchise decided against holding a victory parade in the city in order to avoid the crowd frenzy, which led to last year's deadly stampede.

The RCB took such a decision also keeping in mind the swearing-in ceremony of newly-appointed Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar. The function is scheduled to be held at Lok Bhavan at 4.10 pm and the Governor's residence is in close proximity to Chinnaswamy Stadium. The political function is expected to attract a massive crowd from across the state. The ceremony, which is to be attended by several dignitaries, will also require considerable deployment of police personnel, and it will be tough for the state police department to spare men for another high-voltage function.

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TAUNTON: Indian team will expect more from the dependable duo of Deepti Sharma and Richa Ghosh as it aims to sort out its middle order woes going into the third and final women's T20 International against hosts England here on Tuesday.

With the series locked at 1-1, a victory in the decider will not just be another overseas bilateral win but a shot in the arm for either team before the start of the Women's T20 World Cup later this month.

For India, this series is also the dress rehearsal to check out the ideal combinations based on English conditions going into the marquee event.

In the first couple of games, Yastika Bhatia with a half-century and a 30 odd has by far looked the best batter. Jemimah Rodrigues also got a fifty while the elegant Smriti Mandhana and destructive Shafali Verma got starts in the second match.

However, in both games India lost momentum towards

the last five overs and the big-hitter Richa hasn't exactly fired in both games. In the first game, fabulous batting by Bhatia and Rodrigues had ensured that India ended up with a healthy 188/7 despite only 40 runs being scored between overs 16 and 20. In the second game, India were sitting pretty at 70 for 1 in a chase of 169 but it was an unmitigated disaster between overs 16 and 20 when they were reduced to 28/5.

Govt achieves fiscal deficit target of 4.4% for FY26, deficit at 21% in April

The CGA data showed that the fiscal deficit in actual terms was Rs 15,19,169 crore (provisional), or 97.5 per cent, of the revised estimates

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government has achieved its fiscal deficit target of 4.4 per cent of the GDP for 2025-26, according to data released by the Controller General of Accounts (CGA) on Monday.

In the revised estimates (RE) presented in Parliament in February, the government pegged the fiscal deficit, or gap between expenditure and revenue, at Rs 15,58,492 crore or 4.4 per cent of gross domestic product (GDP).

The CGA data showed that the fiscal deficit in actual terms was Rs 15,19,169 crore (provisional), or 97.5 per cent, of the RE.

For April 2026, the fiscal deficit stood at 21 per cent of the Budget Estimate, much higher than normal for the first month of a fiscal year. This indicates more expenditure than the revenue mobilisation.

As per the CGA data, the government managed to collect Rs 33.02 lakh crore in revenue, or 98.8 per cent of the revised Budget Estimates (RE).

This comprised Rs 26.23 lakh crore tax revenue (net to Centre), Rs 6.78 lakh crore of non-tax revenue and Rs 83,757 crore of non-debt capital



As per the CGA data, the govt managed to collect Rs 33.02 lakh crore in revenue, or 98.8% of revised Budget Estimates

receipts, the CGA data showed. Non-debt capital receipts consist of recovery of loans (Rs 24,617 crore) and miscellaneous capital receipts (Rs 59,140 crore).

The total expenditure incurred by the Centre is Rs 49.05 lakh crore (98.8 per cent of the corresponding RE 2025-26), out of which Rs 38.36 lakh crore is on revenue account and Rs 10.69 lakh crore is on capital account.

Highlights

- » The revenue comprised Rs 26.23 lakh crore tax revenue (net to Centre), Rs 6.78 lakh crore of non-tax revenue and Rs 83,757 crore of non-debt capital receipts
- » Non-debt capital receipts consist of recovery of loans (Rs 24,617 cr) & miscellaneous capital receipts (Rs 59,140 cr)
- » Total expenditure incurred by Centre is Rs 49.05 lakh cr (98.8% of corresponding RE 2025-26)

Out of the total revenue expenditure, Rs 12.42 lakh crore is on account of interest payments, and Rs 4.53 lakh crore is on account of major subsidies.

The government's fiscal deficit for 2024-25 was 4.8 per cent of the GDP.

Commenting on the deficit numbers, Iкра Chief Economist Aditi Nayar said the government's fiscal deficit trailed the Revised Estimate (RE) for

FY26 by Rs 40,000 crore, aided by a Rs 60,000 crore expenditure cut, which more than offset the marginal miss on the receipts front.

This enabled the fiscal deficit to be contained at 4.4 per cent of GDP in FY26, in line with the target for the fiscal, notwithstanding the downward revision in nominal GDP prints, she said.

Interestingly, inflows on account of savings deposits, certificates and PPF exceeded the RE by about Rs 1 lakh crore, higher than Iкра's expectations. This led to an increase in the cash balance of the government against the Rs 45,700 crore drawdown that was envisaged as per the RE, she said.

This is expected to provide some cushion to the government's fiscal position in FY27, and prevent any fiscal slippage from translating into an equivalent increase in market borrowings, she added.

For April, the fiscal deficit stood at 21.4 per cent of the Budget Estimate at Rs 3,62,303 crore.

The government has estimated a fiscal deficit of Rs 16,95,768 crore for the entire FY27. The government collected total revenue of Rs 2,02,785 crore, 5.7 per cent of

the Budget Estimate of Rs 35.33 lakh crore for the current fiscal.

However, total expenditure was higher at Rs 5,74,982 crore, 10.8 per cent of the Rs 53.47 lakh estimated in the Budget for FY27.

The government's fiscal started off FY27 on an expectedly sombre note, with an annual dip in tax and non-tax revenues and sharp expansion in both revenue and capital spending, resulting in a near doubling of the fiscal deficit in April 2026 in year-on-year terms, Nayar said.

While fiscal risks abound in the form of higher than budgeted fertiliser and LPG subsidies, and shortfalls in excise duty, corporate tax, and dividend from the OMCs, a portion of the stress would be absorbed by higher import duty on gold and silver, and the balance in the Economic Stabilisation Fund, she said.

"While we estimate the slippage in the fiscal deficit at around 0.3 per cent of GDP relative to the FY27 BE, the incremental borrowing requirement would be softened by the higher opening cash balance vis-a-vis the BE, partly benefitting from the overshooting in small savings collections in FY26," she said.

GST collections grow 3.2% in May to ₹1.94 lakh crore

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Gross GST collections rose 3.2 per cent to over Rs 1.94 lakh crore in May on higher supplies of goods and services, as well as collection from imports, government data showed on Monday.

Gross GST collection was Rs 1.88 lakh crore in May 2025. Gross Central GST (CGST) collection from domestic transactions during the reported month stood at Rs 37,397 crore, State GST (SGST) at Rs 45,143 crore and Integrated GST (IGST) at Rs 51,990 crore.

Taxable supplies of goods grew 26.9 per cent during the reported period, reflecting higher domestic demand, while the same for the services sector grew 22.2 per cent, demonstrating structural resilience in domestic consumption.

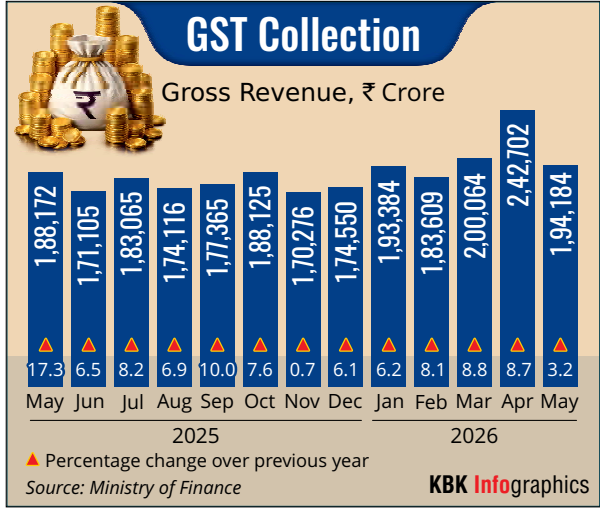
IGST collection from imports rose 19.1 per cent during May to Rs 59,654 crore, signalling expansion in industrial capacity.

Goods and Services Tax (GST) refunds grew 2.6 per cent to Rs 27,281 crore.

After adjusting refunds, net GST revenues in May rose 3.3 per cent to about Rs 1.67 lakh crore.

GST mop-up in April reached an all-time high of Rs 2.43 lakh crore.

On a cumulative basis for the first two months of FY2026-27 (April and May), gross GST collections stand at Rs 4.37 lakh crore compared to



Rs 4.11 lakh crore in the corresponding period of FY2025-26, a growth of 6.2 per cent.

"This cumulative year-on-year performance is healthy and in the right direction to achieve the full-year GST revenue target," sources said.

The government has budgeted to mop up Rs 10.19 lakh crore from GST in the current fiscal.

Commenting on the numbers, Price Waterhouse & Co LLP partner Pratik Jain said collectively for April and May 26, collections show a robust 8.8 per cent year-on-year growth on a like-for-like basis.

This is despite the steep rate cuts from September 2025 and geopolitical disruptions during the last couple of months, he said, adding that imports and domestic consumption of products and services have expanded significantly, which shows economic resilience.

Given the increase in input costs due to supply chain issues, this might be the right time for the government to consider providing working capital support to industry by relaxing refund provisions with respect to input GST, which has been accumulating for many businesses, he added.

"While import GST has recorded a near 20 per cent growth, this may also be attributed to rupee depreciation. Adjusted for the one-time telecom payment in the base, domestic collections reflect moderate growth in line with prevailing economic conditions," KPMG Indirect Tax Head & Partner Abhishek Jain said.

RBI clears 99.9% citizen charter requests within time

MUMBAI: The RBI on Monday said it has processed 99.9 per cent of applications within the prescribed timeline under its Citizen's Charter in May 2026, according to official data.

The RBI said it handled a total of 18,763 applications in May, including pending cases and fresh receipts, after adjusting for those referred back to applicants for additional information.

As many as 2,473 applications were pending at the beginning of May, while 16,865 fresh applications were received during the month. A total of 575 cases were referred back to applicants for additional details, taking the net number of applications for processing to 18,763.

Of these, 16,209 applications were processed during May. As many as 16,193 cases, or 99.9 per cent, were disposed of within the stipulated timeline, while only 16 cases, or 0.1 per cent were cleared beyond the deadline, RBI data showed.

At the end of the month, 2,554 applications remained pending, of which 2,539 cases, or 99.4 per cent were still within the prescribed timeline and 15 cases, or 0.6 per cent were beyond it.

Of the delayed cases, 14 were awaiting inputs from external agencies, and one is under process, the RBI said.

India's seafood exports hit record high in FY26: MPEDA

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOCHI: India's seafood exports hit a record high in both volume and value during 2025-26, reaching 19,72,018 metric tonnes worth Rs 73,890.46 crore (\$8.46 billion), despite global challenges, MPEDA Chairman P Jawahar said on Monday.

The Kochi-based Marine Products Export Development Authority is a statutory body established under the Ministry of Commerce and Industry, Government of India, to promote and regulate the export of marine products.

According to Marine Products Export Development Authority (MPEDA) figures, the US and China remained the top importers of Indian seafood during the fiscal year, while frozen shrimp continued to dominate the export basket.

Frozen shrimp, the leading export item, generated Rs 49,037.93 crore (\$5,624.48 million), accounting for 40.19 per cent of the total quantity exported and 66.52 per cent of total dollar earnings from seafood exports, a statement said.

During FY26, India exported 7,92,647 MT of frozen shrimp. Shrimp exports registered growth of 13.16 per cent in rupee terms and 8.64 per cent in dollar terms.

The United States remained the largest market for frozen shrimp, importing 2,56,128 MT, followed by China (1,69,505 MT), the European Union (1,35,599 MT), South-east Asia (83,810 MT), Japan (40,776 MT), the Middle East (30,478 MT), and other countries (76,351 MT), the statement added.

Exports of L vannamei



(Whiteleg shrimp) and Black Tiger shrimp recorded growth in both volume and value, Jawahar said.

Frozen fish was the second-largest export item, earning Rs 5,658.37 crore (\$643.70 million), while dried products emerged as the third-largest export category with earnings of Rs 5,079.09 crore (\$577.44 million). Exports of dried products recorded a 78.05 per cent increase in rupee value.

Exports of frozen squid stood at 1,02,060 MT, fetching

Rs 4,493.80 crore (\$513.84 million). Frozen cuttlefish exports rose by 13.32 per cent in volume and 16.25 per cent in dollar value, reaching 67,157 MT worth \$331.96 million.

Exports of chilled products earned Rs 622.31 crore (\$71.27 million), while live products registered an 11.46 per cent increase in dollar earnings to \$62.43 million.

Among overseas markets, the United States remained the leading importer of Indian seafood in value terms, importing 2,79,193 MT worth Rs 20,263.27 crore (\$2,328.74 million).

However, exports to the US declined by 10.82 per cent in rupee value, 14.22 per cent in dollar value, and 19.51 per cent in volume. Frozen shrimp accounted for 93.55 per cent of the value of India's seafood exports to the US, the statement said.

China emerged as the largest destination in volume terms, importing 4,90,369 MT worth \$1,611.32 million.

The European Union remained the third-largest destination in dollar terms, importing 2,97,518 MT worth \$1,592.09 million. It was followed by Southeast Asia, which imported 4,51,756 MT worth \$1,348.97 million.

Japan continued to be the fifth-largest importer in value terms, importing 1,05,228 MT worth \$452.91 million, while the Middle East ranked sixth with imports of 76,743 MT valued at \$283 million.

The top three ports handling seafood cargo during the year were Visakhapatnam Port, Jawaharlal Nehru Port Trust (JNPT), and Kochi Port, the statement added.

Higher gold duty likely to boost Gold ETFs, Gold Mutual Funds and GTRs: Kotak Mutual Fund

NEW DELHI: The recent increase in gold import duty to 15 per cent is likely to strengthen the case for financial gold products such as Gold ETFs, Gold Mutual Funds and Gold Trading Receipts (GTRs), according to Satish Dondapati, ETF Fund Manager at Kotak Mutual Fund.

Dondapati said the duty hike has already pushed up domestic gold prices, resulting in higher net asset values (NAVs) for Gold ETFs and Gold Funds. He added that the move aligns with the government's objective of moderating physical gold consumption and encouraging investors to shift towards financial forms of gold ownership.

A greater preference for



Gold ETFs and GTRs over jewellery and coins could also help reduce pressure on India's current account deficit and foreign exchange reserves over time. India imports around 800 tonnes of gold annually, with nearly 70 per cent used for jewellery, 28 per cent for investments and the remainder for industrial purposes. Increasing adoption of financial gold products could help channel savings into less import-intensive investment avenues, he said.

Explaining the difference between GTRs and Gold ETFs, Dondapati noted that both provide exposure to gold prices without requiring physical possession and are backed by gold held in regulated vaults. However, Gold ETFs generally offer greater liquidity and broader investor participation, while taxation may vary depending on regulatory treatment and holding period.

On the outlook for gold, he said the precious metal is likely to remain well supported over the next 12 months if geopolitical tensions persist, the rupee remains weak and global growth slows. Gold typically benefits from safe-haven demand during

periods of uncertainty, while a weaker rupee boosts domestic prices by making imports more expensive.

Although a weaker rupee supports returns for Indian investors, Dondapati said US bond yields and Federal Reserve policy are likely to exert a greater influence on global gold prices.

Given elevated equity valuations and rising geopolitical risks, he recommended allocating 10-15 per cent of a diversified portfolio to gold. However, he advised investors to build exposure gradually through staggered investments rather than lump-sum allocations, in line with their asset allocation goals and investment horizon.

India's exports grow in double digits in April-May, says Official

NEW DELHI: The country's exports have recorded a double-digit growth during April-May 2026-27, a senior government official said on Monday. The Commerce Ministry will release the trade data for May on June 15. "During the two months, exports are in double-digit growth," the official said.

Exports rose by 13.78 per cent to \$43.56 billion in April, the highest monthly outbound shipments in more than four years, driven by petroleum products amid a surge in crude oil prices, but the trade deficit widened to a three-month high of \$28.38 billion due to an uptick in imports.

The official also said that the

commerce ministry will be hiring 1,000 people from across the country to disseminate information about free trade agreements being finalised by India.

"We need people from different languages," the official said, adding that paperwork is underway for the hiring process.

India has implemented FTAs with the UAE, Oman, Australia, the EFTA bloc and Mauritius. It has also finalised these pacts with the UK, New Zealand and the EU.

Further, while addressing the media on the India-Oman free trade agreement, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said this pact is part of India's nine free trade

agreements finalised in the last three and a half years, which cover 38 developed nations.

These pacts secure preferential market access for goods and services from India, covering nearly two-thirds of global trade, he said.

"Our target is clear, one trillion dollars of exports in the current year and two trillion dollars of exports five years from now and towards that we are further negotiating free trade agreements with Israel, Canada, the six-nation GCC block," Goyal said. He informed that India will soon launch talks for a trade pact with SACU (South Africa Customs Union) led by South Africa.

India-Oman trade pact comes into force, grants duty-free access to 99% of Indian exports

The agreement comes at a significant time as Indian exporters face shipping disruptions in the Gulf region amid the ongoing US-Iran conflict

NEW DELHI: The India-Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) came into force on Monday, granting duty-free access to 99.38 per cent of India's exports to Oman and providing enhanced mobility provisions for Indian professionals, while also allowing quota-based duty concessions on imports of Omani dates.

The agreement comes at a significant time as Indian exporters face shipping disruptions in the Gulf region amid the ongoing US-Iran conflict.

Under the pact, Oman will eliminate duties on 98.08 per cent of its tariff lines, covering nearly all Indian exports

by value. India, in turn, has extended tariff concessions on 77.79 per cent of its tariff lines, accounting for 94.81 per cent of imports from Oman. For sensitive products such as dates, marble and petrochemicals, concessions are being provided through tariff-rate quotas.

To mark the implementation of the pact, the first consignments availing preferential tariffs, including agricultural products and gems and jewellery exports from Mumbai, Kolkata and Chennai, were flagged off. Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said the agreement would create new opportunities for exporters and professionals while



boosting labour-intensive sectors such as textiles, gems and jewel-lery, leather, footwear, marine products, engineering

goods, processed foods and pharmaceuticals.

Bilateral trade between India and Oman rose to \$11.18 billion

CLOSER LOOK

- » Under the pact, Oman will eliminate duties on 98.08% of its tariff lines, covering nearly all Indian exports by value
- » India, in turn, has extended tariff concessions on 77.79% of its tariff lines, accounting for 94.81% of imports from Oman

in FY26 from \$10.61 billion in FY25. The pact is expected to further strengthen trade by improving the competitiveness

of Indian products in Oman's nearly \$28-billion import market. Earlier, only 15.33 per cent of India's exports entered Oman duty-free under the most-favoured nation regime.

The agreement offers significant opportunities for pharmaceutical and electronics exporters. Oman's pharmaceutical market is projected to grow from about \$303 million in 2025 to nearly \$474 million by 2031, while the Gulf nation imported around \$1.7 billion worth of electronics products in 2025. Faster regulatory approvals and acceptance of international manufacturing and inspection standards are expected to ease market access

for Indian drug makers.

In services, Oman has made broad commitments across professional, business, education, health and computer-related services. For the first time, it has expanded access for skilled professionals by increasing the quota for intra-corporate transferees from 20 per cent to 50 per cent and extending the stay period for contractual service suppliers from 90 days to up to two years, with a possible extension.

Business visitors will be allowed to stay for up to 90 days, independent professionals for up to 180 days and intra-corporate transferees for up to four years. The provisions are

expected to benefit nearly 6,000 India-Oman joint ventures.

India has excluded sensitive sectors such as agriculture, dairy products, edible oils, spices, gold and silver bullion and several MSME-linked products from tariff concessions to protect domestic interests.

The pact is India's fifth major trade agreement to become operational in the past five years, following agreements with the UAE, Mauritius, Australia and the European Free Trade Association (EFTA). It is expected to add about \$2 billion to bilateral trade over the next two to three years and deepen economic ties between the two countries.

India's industrial production growth declines to 4.9% in April

This is the 1st data released after revision of the base year to 2022-23

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India's industrial production expanded at a slower pace of 4.9 per cent in April due to tepid growth in the energy sector amid the West Asia crisis, according to official data released on Monday.

This is the first data released after the revision of the base year to 2022-23 and the rejigging of the index constituents. The factory output, measured in terms of the Index of Industrial Production (IIP), expanded by 5.7 per cent in April 2025.

The growth rate was 3.2 per cent in March 2026. "Driven by strong growth of 6.2 per cent in manufacturing sector, IIP records 4.9 per cent growth in April 2026," the Ministry of Statistics & Programme Implementation (MoSPI) said in a statement.

The growth rates of the four sectors — mining & quarrying, manufacturing, electricity & gas supply, water supply, sewerage and waste management — for April 2026 stood at (-) 5.1 per cent, 6.2 per cent, 4.9 per cent and 6.6 per cent, respectively, it said. The quick estimate of IIP stands at 118.9 against 113.1 in April 2025.

The MoSPI has revised the

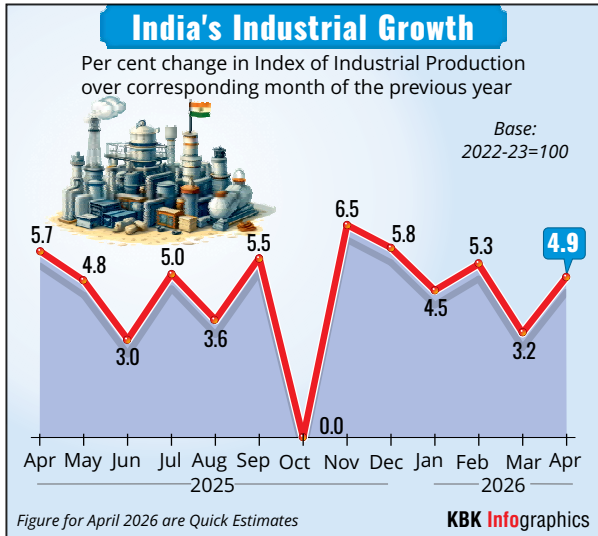


Figure for April 2026 are Quick Estimates

Highlights

» Quick estimate of Index of Industrial Production stands at 118.9 against 113.1 in April 2025

» The Ministry of Statistics & Programme Implementation (MoSPI) has revised the base year of the IIP from 2011-12 to 2022-23

» The revised basket consists of 1,042 products mapped to 463 item groups, including 120 new item groups

base year of the IIP from 2011-12 to 2022-23. The revised basket consists of 1,042 products mapped to 463 item groups, including 120 new item groups.

The base year revision exercise was undertaken under the aegis of the Technical Advisory Committee for Base Year Revision of the All India Index of Industrial Production (TAC-IIP). The committee's report was released on May 25, 2026, laying the foundation for a more robust, relevant, and comprehensive measure of industrial

production in India.

This is the 10th revision of the base year for IIP. The first IIP was prepared with a base year 1937. According to the MoSPI, the new IIP series provides greater granularity with separate indices for the generation of electricity through renewable and non-renewable, gas supply, fuel minerals, metallic minerals and non-metallic minerals, water supply, sewerage and waste management.

In the new IIP series, a total of 120 new item groups have

been added, including cards with a magnetic stripe (debit card, credit card), CCTV camera, articles of non-woven textiles, parts of aircraft and spacecraft, stents, and vaccine.

Also, 64 item groups, including kerosene, fluorescent tubes and CFLs, tubes for bicycle/tricycle/ rickshaw/LMV tyres, printing machinery, and sewing machines, have been dropped.

An expanded item basket improves representativeness, captures diversification in industrial production, and

reflects emerging industrial products and technologies, MoSPI said, adding that the IIP will be released every month with a time lag of 28 days from the reference month.

Briefing the media after the release of the index, MoSPI Secretary Saurabh Garg said the new IIP series plugs gaps in previous batch, and has included minor mineral. Also, greater weightage has been assigned to plastic, rubber, and automobiles in the new series, he informed. "I would also like to highlight that the data gaps that we had in the previous IIP we have filled that," the secretary said, and explained about the new additions in the series, including gas supplies, minor minerals and rare earth minerals.

According to the new IIP series, within the manufacturing sector, 17 out of 23 industry groups recorded a positive growth in April 2026 over April 2025. The top three positive contributors during April 2026 were: 'manufacture of motor vehicles, trailers and semi-trailers' (12.7 per cent), 'manufacture of electrical equipment' (19.2 per cent) and 'manufacture of machinery and equipment n.e.c.' (12.9 per cent), the IIP data showed.

Mfg growth hits 3-month high in May as domestic mkt fuels activity

OUR CORRESPONDENT

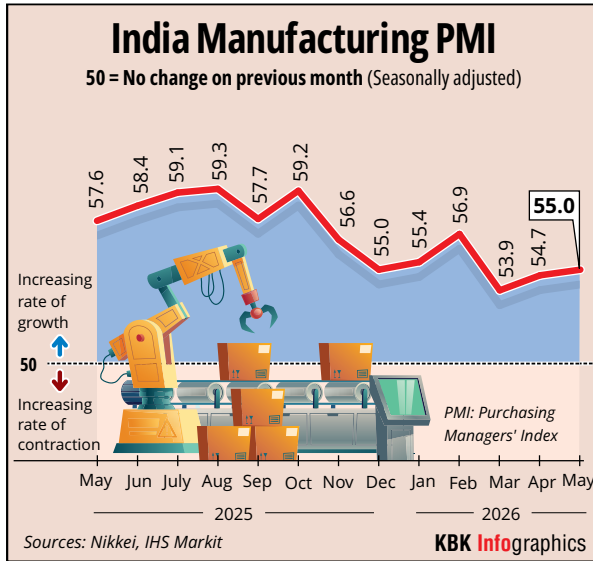
NEW DELHI: India's manufacturing sector activity growth accelerated to a three-month high in May, driven by demand strength, infrastructure projects and new business gains, even amid inflationary pressures, a monthly survey said on Monday.

The seasonally adjusted HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) posted 55.0 in May, above the April reading of 54.7, indicating the strongest improvement in the sector's health in three months.

HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) is a gauge of overall conditions derived from measures of new orders, output, employment, supplier delivery times and stocks of purchases.

In the PMI parlance, a print above 50 means expansion, while a score below 50 denotes contraction. Goods producers reported the fastest expansions in new orders and output since February and cited factors like demand strength, infrastructure projects, and new business gains as the main reasons behind the upturn.

"India's final manufacturing PMI points to another month of possible precautionary stockpiling as the Middle East conflict remains unresolved. Output growth accelerated, while purchasing activity and stocks of finished goods rose at a faster pace," said Pranjul Bhandari,



Sources: Nikkei, IHS Markit

Chief India Economist at HSBC.

Underlying data showed that the domestic market provided impetus to growth, as new export orders rose at a softer pace. On the price front, the war in the Middle East continued to exert pressure on cost burdens. Panel members signalled greater outlays on energy, fuel, materials and transportation.

"Input cost inflation eased slightly on the month, and output price inflation slowed more sharply, suggesting a potential squeeze on manufacturers' margins," Bhandari said.

Notwithstanding sharp increases in input costs, goods producers purchased more materials in May. Moreover, the pace of growth in buying levels was sharp, the quickest

in three months and above the historical trend. Underpinning the rise were attempts to raise contingency stocks.

Meanwhile, greater production requirements induced another round of job creation across India's manufacturing industry. The rate of expansion was solid, despite slowing from April. Business confidence remained positive, with companies hoping that cost pressures will fade later in the year. Advertising and strong order pipelines also supported optimism towards growth prospects.

The HSBC India Manufacturing PMI is compiled by S&P Global from responses to questionnaires sent to purchasing managers in a panel of around 400 manufacturers.

Rupee falls 34 paise to 95.19 against dollar



MUMBAI: The rupee depreciated 34 paise to close at 95.19 against the US dollar on Monday, amid renewed geopolitical tensions between the US and Iran and a surge in crude oil prices.

Forex traders said the strength of the American currency in the overseas market and Israel-Lebanon tensions also deteriorated global risk sentiments.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 94.93 against the US dollar, then touched an intraday high of 94.73 and a low of 95.03 during the day.

At the end of Monday's trading session, the rupee was quoted at 95.19, down 34 paise from its previous close.

On Friday, the rupee appreciated 73 paise to close at 94.85 against the US dollar on suspected interventions by the RBI.

Forex traders said attention has now shifted toward the upcoming RBI Monetary Policy Committee meeting scheduled for June 3-5. The six-member Monetary Policy Committee will announce its decision on June 5. Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.04, up 0.10 per cent.

PTI

Govt issues second global tender for 70 lakh tonne urea imports

The global price of urea has increased from \$447 per tonne in February to \$947 per tonne now

NEW DELHI: The government has issued a second global tender for the import of 70 lakh tonne of urea despite a sharp rise in global prices to boost domestic supplies for the kharif season, a senior Fertiliser Ministry official said on Monday.

The global price of urea has increased from \$447 per tonne in February to \$947 per tonne now, Aparna S Sharma, additional secretary in the Fertiliser Ministry said. India has secured 25 lakh tonne of urea & 50 lakh tonne of di-ammonium phosphate (DAP) from sources outside the Strait of Hormuz, with arrivals expected in June-July.

"We have also issued a global tender for 70 lakh tonne of urea,

Urea demand for kharif 2026-27 season is pegged at 194 lakh tonne, lower by 4 lakh tonne

which is in progress. ...This is the second tender for the kharif season. The price in the global tender is yet to be discovered," she said. The domestic fertiliser production stood at 104.81 lakh tonne amid the West Asia crisis, while imports were 27.62 lakh tonne, taking total additions to availability to approximately 132.43 lakh tonne.

Factoring in the El Nino outlook, the agriculture ministry has revised fertiliser demand estimates downward in consultation with state governments.

Urea demand for the kharif 2026-27 season is pegged at 194 lakh tonne, lower by 4 lakh tonne, while DAP demand has been cut by 6 lakh tonne to 60 lakh tonne, she added.

Kharif (summer) sowing has just begun in some parts of India, but it is still in the very early stages. Farmers have started preparing fields for early sowing (especially of short-duration crops like pulses, coarse cereals, and some cotton) in regions that have received pre-monsoon rains.

PTI

UPI transactions hit record high of ₹29.90L cr and 23.2 billion in value, volume terms in May

NEW DELHI: Summer travel and IPL fever pushed transaction through the popular Unified Payments Interface (UPI) to a record highs of Rs 29.90 lakh crore and 23.2 billion in value and volume terms, respectively, in May, according to data released by the National Payments Corporation of India.

National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) said the value of transactions was at Rs 29.03 lakh crore in April against Rs 25.14 lakh crore in the same month a year ago, registering a 19 per cent growth on an annual basis.

In volume terms, it set a new record with 23.2 billion



transactions during the month, up 24 per cent from 18.67 billion in the corresponding period.

The UPI transaction in volume terms was 22.35 billion recorded in April, 2026.

According to Cashfree Payments co-founder & CEO Akash Sinha, May's numbers reflect strong organic

demand. Summer travel, IPL 2026, and seasonal consumer spending drove 23.20 billion transactions worth Rs 29.90 lakh crore during the month, which is a healthy month-on-month recovery and a continuation of UPI's steady upward trajectory.

The Reserve Bank of India's Payments Systems Report shows UPI's average ticket size has declined from Rs 1,848 in 2021 to Rs 1,313 in 2025, he said, adding, this is not a concern, it is a sign of a maturing ecosystem.

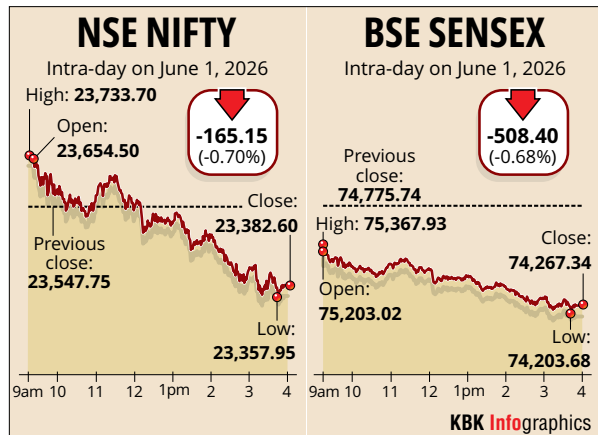
"The next growth frontier will be additive to all of this. Credit-on-UPI is still in early innings and represents a sig-

nificant new volume pool. Cross-border UPI is live in over eight countries and expanding, bringing a whole new transaction category onto the rails," he added.

UPI already live in seven countries, including the UAE, Singapore, Bhutan, Nepal, and Mauritius.

NPCI, an initiative of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the Indian Banks' Association, is an umbrella organisation for operating retail payments and settlement systems in India (IBA).

It runs the UPI used for real-time payments between peers or at merchants' end, while making purchases.



Tech Mahindra, Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services, InterGlobe Aviation, HCL Tech and Tata Steel were the gainers.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, traded 3.34 per cent higher at \$94.16 per barrel.

The US on Monday said

that it bombed radar and drone sites in Iran after Tehran shot down an American drone over the weekend. Iran then said it launched a strike of its own, and Kuwait reported incoming fire. The nominal ceasefire between Iran and the US has

been repeatedly tested with such back-and-forth attacks, even as officials from both countries try to negotiate an end to the war.

Broader markets also declined with the BSE MidCap Select index declining 1.44 per cent and BSE SmallCap Select index by 0.72 per cent.

Power dropped 2.90 per cent, followed by Capital Goods (2.44 per cent), Utilities (2.12 per cent), Industrials (2.11 per cent), Realty (2.03 per cent) and FMCG (2.02 per cent). IT, Energy, Metal and Focused IT were the gainers.

A total of 2,761 stocks declined, while 1,589 advanced and 199 remained unchanged on the BSE.

In four days, the BSE benchmark has tumbled 2,221.62 points, or 2.90 per cent, and the Nifty tanked 649.1 points, or 2.70 per cent.

PTI

Vedanta gets clearance from Odisha govt for Sijimali mine access road

NEW DELHI: The Odisha government has approved construction of a 3.4-km access road to the proposed Sijimali bauxite mine in Rayagada district after the Union environment ministry granted final forest clearance for diversion of land linked to the project.

The road is considered critical for operationalising the Vedanta-linked mining project, which continues to face legal challenges and opposition from tribal communities.

The state has allowed diversion of 4.91 hectares of forest land in favour of the Odisha Industrial Infrastructure Development Corporation (IDCO), the project's implementing

agency.

The road will connect the hilltop mine with State Highway-44 and a nearby railway siding, facilitating transportation of bauxite from the lease area. The issue has been contentious, with clashes between local residents and authorities in April leaving 70 people injured, including 58 police personnel.

The environment ministry has directed Odisha to undertake compensatory afforestation on 6.07 hect-tares of non-forest land within two years.

However, the clearance remains subject to the outcome of petitions pending before the National Green Tribunal, where activists have challenged forest

diversion and related approvals.

Vedanta, which won the Sijimali block in 2023, plans to mine nearly 9 million tonnes of bauxite annually to partly supply its alumina refinery at Lanjigarh.

The project seeks to tap an estimated 311 million tonnes of reserves and involves diversion of more than 709 hectares of forest land across Rayagada and Kalahandi districts.

The mine also faces a separate legal dispute in the Supreme Court, while tribal communities continue to oppose the project, citing concerns over forest rights, livelihoods and sacred sites. The project is expected to displace 129 families.

AGENCIES

Indian startup funding declines 27.2% month-on-month to \$630 million in May

The downturn was largely offset by mobility platform Rapido's \$240 mn funding round, which accounted for a substantial share of month's capital raised

NEW DELHI: Funding activity in Indian startups slowed sharply in May 2026, with total investments declining 27.2 per cent month-on-month to \$630 million from \$865 million in April. The downturn was largely offset by mobility platform Rapido's \$240 million funding round, which accounted for a substantial share of the month's capital raised.

Indian startups secured about \$630 million across 63 disclosed funding deals during May, including 12 growth and late-stage transactions worth \$492 million and 51 early-stage deals totaling \$137 million. Another 10 deals remained

undisclosed. Funding was down 45 per cent year-on-year, making May the weakest month for startup fundraising in six years and the lowest since July 2025.

Rapido emerged as the largest fundraiser with a \$240 million Series F round. Other notable late-stage deals included fintech startup Scapi's \$63 million raise and Hyderabad-based Skyroot Aerospace's \$60 million funding round, which made it India's first aerospace unicorn. Edtech firm upGrad secured \$38 million, while home-services startup Pronto raised \$20 million. Ecofy, StrainX Bioworks, Wingreens, Anveshan and Country Delight also featured among the larger

transactions.

At the early stage, B2B commerce platform Fairdeal. Market led with a \$15 million round. Semiconductor startups continued to attract investor attention, with HrdWyr raising \$13 million and BigEndian Semiconductor securing \$6 million. AI startups Human Archive and Mythik raised \$8.2 million and \$5 million, respectively, while robotics, manufacturing and consumer-focused ventures also drew fresh capital.

IPO activity remained subdued, with only Kissht making its stock market debut during the month. However, quick-commerce player Zepto received approval from SEBI

CLOSER LOOK

» Hyderabad-based Skyroot Aerospace's \$60 million funding round, made it India's first aerospace unicorn

» Edtech firm upGrad secured \$38 million, while home-services startup Pronto raised \$20 million

» Semiconductor startups continued to attract investor attention, with HrdWyr raising \$13 million and BigEndian Semiconductor securing \$6 million

for its proposed initial public offering.

Acquisition activity remained strong across fintech, AI, healthcare and consumer sectors. Key deals included InMobi's acquisition of Mobile-Action, Netradyn's purchase of Moove, Freo's acquisition

of IndiaLends, Oxyzo's move to acquire GoldenPi, Emami's acquisition of a majority stake in InCut Digital, and Wingreens' purchase of Safe Harvest.

Bengaluru retained its position as the country's leading startup hub, attracting \$411.1 million across 35 deals and

accounting for more than 65 per cent of total funding. Mumbai followed with \$71 million, while Hyderabad raised \$60.4 million and Delhi-NCR secured \$44.9 million.

Sector-wise, fintech led fundraising with \$97.2 million across 10 deals, followed by e-commerce at \$43.4 million and AI at \$26.1 million. Funding activity continued to favour early and mid-stage companies, with Series A rounds accounting for \$73.6 million across 12 deals.

The month also highlighted growing pressure on startups to control costs. Innovaccer, Adda247, Pocket FM and Apna Mart collectively laid off around

680 employees, a sharp rise from approximately 120 layoffs reported in April. The ecosystem witnessed one shutdown as spiritual app DevDham ceased operations.

Leadership churn remained elevated, with 12 senior-level departures across startups including ShareMarket, Fashionza, Fi Money, Unacademy and Pocket FM. At the same time, companies announced 32 key leadership appointments.

No ESOP buybacks were reported in April or May after startups collectively repurchased nearly \$220 million worth of employee stock options during the first quarter of 2026.

The month also saw a major regulatory development as the Supreme Court upheld the retrospective 28 per cent GST levy on online gaming, validating tax demands exceeding Rs 1 lakh crore. Meanwhile, "Physical AI" emerged as a prominent theme in the startup ecosystem, driven by discussions around companies such as Pronto, Snabbit and Urban Company.

Despite continued investor interest in sectors such as space tech, semiconductors, AI and fintech, May reflected a more cautious funding environment, with investors prioritising scale, profitability and execution over aggressive capital deployment.

AGENCIES



‘ALIA & RANBIR ARE MY FAVOURITES’

Bobby Deol dismissed rumours of any tiff between him and her on the sets of ‘Alpha’

Within a span of three years, Bobby Deol locked horns with both Ranbir Kapoor and Alia Bhatt. First, he played the chief antagonist in Sandeep Reddy Vanga’s 2023 blockbuster family crime drama ‘Animal’, headlined by Ranbir Kapoor. He’ll next be seen as the main villain in Shiv Rawail’s spy thriller ‘Alpha’, starring Alia Bhatt.

But Bobby maintained that the antagonism is limited to the films, clearing the air on the rumours that all didn’t go down well between him and Alia on the sets of the latter.

“A friend also shared a snapshot of that with me. I was so shocked. People are so ‘vella’ that they say anything,” said Bobby, laughing. “After I did ‘Animal’ with Ranbir, I was offered a film with Alia. I thought, ‘What’s happening? How come I’m getting to work with two of my favourites?’” he added, claiming that even though he’d fond of the couple, they don’t end up meeting that often.

He added, “First of all, she’s such a good actor. She’s a professional and so hardworking. She was so prepared in her fight sequences,” Bobby lauded Alia on ‘Aap Ki Adalat’, implying that there was no reason for him to have an unpleasant experience with her on set. “They even said that Bobby was so upset that Aditya Chopra offered him another film.”

Aditya Chopra’s ‘Yash Raj Films’ is the producer of ‘Alpha’, which is a part of the ‘YRF Spy Universe’, that already consists of blockbusters like ‘Pathaan’ (2023), Salman Khan and Katrina Kaif-starrer franchise ‘Tiger’ and Hrithik Roshan-starrer ‘War’ franchise. Its next chapter is ‘Alpha’, which also stars Sharvari and Anil Kapoor among others. Marking the feature directorial debut of Rawail, it’s slated to release in cinemas on July 3.

AGENCIES



‘A friend also shared a snapshot of that with me. I was so shocked. People are so ‘vella’ that they say anything,’ says Deol

Singer Suman Kalyanpur dies at 89

The veteran singer gave her voice to hits such as ‘Na Na Karte’ and ‘Tumne pukara’



Kalyanpur gained popularity with her melodious voice between the 1960s and 1970s

MUMBAI: Veteran singer Suman Kalyanpur, who gave her voice to hits such as ‘Na Na Karte’ and ‘Tumne pukara’, passed away on Sunday evening at her residence due to age-related issues, a close friend said. She was 89.

“Suman ji passed away at around 8 pm at her residence in Lokhandwala due to old age. She passed away peacefully. For the last few days, she was listening to her own songs,” Mangala Khadilkar, who authored the acclaimed Marathi biography ‘Suman Sugandh’ on the singer, told PTI.

Kalyanpur gained popularity with her melodious voice between the 1960s and 1970s. She managed to create a niche for herself alongside the top singer of the time, Lata Mangeshkar.

Some of Kalyanpur’s popular songs are ‘Aajkal tere mere pyar ke charche’, ‘Na na karte pyar tumhin se’, ‘Tumne pukara aur hum chale aaye’ and many others. She sang songs in several languages, includ-

ing Hindi, Marathi, Assamese, Kannada, Bengali, Oriya and others. She also sang devotional songs, ghazals and thumris.

Although many compared her voice to that of the legendary Lata Mangeshkar, Kalyanpur always dismissed the comparison. In a 2022 interview with PTI, she referred to Mangeshkar as a close friend.

“Everyone loved her songs and she will be immortal. We recorded a duet together for the film ‘Chhaand’. Every time I met her, it felt like I met a close friend. I believe she felt the same,” she said at the time.

The last rites for Kalyanpur were to be held at the Pawan Hans crematorium on Monday, from 11:30 am to 12 pm.

The singer is survived by her daughter, Charu. PTI

Oren talks about bringing a darker Spider-Man to 1930s New York

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Now streaming on ‘Prime Video’, Nicholas Cage starrer ‘Spider-Noir’ brings a darker and more mature take on the ‘Spider-Man Universe’, following a private investigator navigating crime-ridden 1930s New York. The series has been met with strong praise from audiences and critics worldwide for its distinctive noir aesthetic and fresh spin on the ‘Spider-Man’ mythos.

For showrunner and executive producer Oren Uziel, whose previous credits include ‘The Lost City’, ‘22 Jump Street’ and ‘Mortal Kombat’, the series offered the chance to combine several of his favourite storytelling

Uziel is the showrunner of Prime Video’s latest release, ‘Spider-Noir’

worlds into one project.

Speaking about what drew him to the series, Uziel said, “I first got involved through the producers Phil Lord, Chris Miller and Amy Pascal. I’ve worked with all of them in the past and always had a great experience. I loved that the project was a live-action ‘Spider-Man’; I loved that it was set in New York in the 1930s and most of all, I loved that it was rooted in the Noir genre. I’ve always been a huge fan of film noir, from the classics straight through the neo-noirs of the past

30, 40, 50 years and counting, so I saw ‘Spider-Noir’ as a magical opportunity to stake my claim to this particular corner of the larger ‘Marvel’ universe.”

Uziel also explained how the series sets itself apart from previous ‘Spider-Man’ adaptations through its central character. “This version of The Spider is different from other on-screen interpretations of Spider-Man in many ways. For starters, he’s called The Spider instead of Spider-Man. He’s also called Ben Reilly instead of Peter Parker. And lastly but most importantly, he’s a lot older than any previous iteration we’ve seen before. This is an adult. A guy who drinks, smokes and isn’t afraid to fight dirty.”



Zendaya-starrer ‘Euphoria’ ends with third season

LOS ANGELES: The makers of psychological drama series ‘Euphoria’, featuring Hollywood star Zendaya, have confirmed the show concluded with the third season.

Created by Sam Levinson, the first season of the series was released in 2019, followed by another season in 2022. The show revolves around the lives of a group of high school students in East Highland, California, as they navigate love, trauma, identity and the pressures of youth culture. It also features Hunter Schafer, Sydney Sweeney, Jacob Elordi and others.

According to the entertainment news outlet ‘Variety’, Levinson, who also serves as a writer and director on the series, announced the news on ‘Popcast’, the New York Times’ music podcast. Following, the streaming platform shared the news with the outlet.

The initial season of ‘Euphoria’,



which consisted of eight episodes, went on to emerge as a cultural phenomenon, with the next season receiving an average of 16.3 million viewers per episode. It also consisted of

eight episodes. The third season, which started streaming in April, featured a time jump and followed the main characters out of school. It also features Chloe Cherry, Alanna Ubach, Toby Wallace and others. PTI

Prime Video unveils the gripping trailer of ‘Raakh’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video’ unveiled a bone-chilling trailer of its upcoming ‘Prime Original’ investigative crime thriller, ‘Raakh’. The trailer offers a glimpse of a brutal and unimaginable crime that not only shatters the victims’ families but also uncovers the disturbing depths of violence and human depravity that exist. The series features Sonali Bendre, Ali Fazal and Aamir Bashir in lead roles, along with Akash Makhija, Raman-deep Yadav, Divya Sharma, Vivaan Sharma, Anshul Chauhan, Rakesh Bedi and Dibyendu Bhattacharya in pivotal roles.

The hard-hitting trailer of ‘Raakh’ begins with a question that no parent ever wants to hear: “Bacche kab se gayab hain?” Set against the backdrop of late 1970s Delhi, at a time when parents believed their children were safe to step outside alone after sunset, a shocking crime shatters this belief for the entire nation. Through haunting, atmospheric montages, the trailer captures the parents’ desperate hope of finding their children. To catch those behind the heinous crime, sub-inspector Jayprakash - played with fierce intensity by Ali Fazal - launches a relentless manhunt that drags him into the twisted psyche of the perpetrators, exposing a lack of morality so extreme it reveals the very darkest corners of human evil.



“When I was first approached for ‘Raakh’, I expected it to be a conventional investigative crime thriller, but the moment I read the script, I was drawn in. Jayprakash is an introvert, the unlikely cop, whose mind I found exciting to explore, along with the minds of the suspects. Flawed, conflicted and constantly trying to prove himself within a rapidly changing political and social environment,” said Ali Fazal.

Sonali Bendre, who plays Mona Arora, shared, “‘Raakh’ came to me at a time when I’ve become very conscious of the stories I choose to be part of. What drew me to it was how layered and emotionally complex it is. While it unfolds as a thriller, at its heart it is a deeply human story.”

‘Vidushi has an undying OPTIMISM’

Saba Azad returns as Dr Vidushi Kothari in ‘Who’s Your Gynac?’ Season 2

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Amazon MX Player’ recently launched the second season of its much-loved comedy drama, ‘Who’s Your Gynac?’. The show follows Dr Vidushi Kothari as she takes the leap towards opening her own clinic while navigating ambition, self-doubt, emotional chaos and the everyday unpredictability of adulthood.

Featuring Saba Azad in the lead role alongside a stellar cast including Karishma Singh, Aaron Arjun Koul, Kunal Thakur, Vibha Chibber and Shruti Seth, the series continues to blend humour with heart, delivering a deeply relatable story about friendship, personal growth and the courage it takes to show up for yourself even when life feels messy.

Opening up about slipping back into the shoes of Dr Vidushi Kothari, Saba Azad shared, “Vidushi has an undying optimism even



when everything around her is falling apart. She stubbornly and almost foolishly refuses to give up, sometimes to a hilarious extent and sometimes that persistence works in her favour. Self-doubt is such a constant companion for so many young professionals and this season really explores her trying to conquer that inner noise. Reconnecting with Vidushi honestly felt like meeting an old goofy friend again. In many ways,

it also felt like coming home, because I can relate to so much about her.”

Reflecting on the emotional depth of the new season and the bond she shares with the cast, she added, “The writing felt more emotional this time around and what stayed constant was the incredible energy on set with our director, Himali and the amazing cast, Aaron, Karishma, Vibha ma’am, Kunal, and Shruti. Vidushi’s friends are her

‘I’d tell her that obsessive self-reliance isn’t the virtue people make it out to be,’ says the actress

anchors. Friends are truly the family you choose and I genuinely believe you’ve done well in life if you have a few good people to grow with and share life alongside.”

Sharing the one piece of advice she would give Vidushi, Saba further shared, “I’d tell her that obsessive self-reliance isn’t the virtue people make it out to be. Human beings grow with each other and because of each other. Asking for help doesn’t make you weaker or less successful; it just makes us more human.”

